THE KALAMAZOO GAZETTE

PROBING NEW CHURCH FIRE

CORPSE LADEN UNDERSEA BOAT JAMS ON REEF

S-51, Rescued from Ocean Tomb, Fast on Rock.

HALTS FUNERAL TRIP

Accident Happens Just as Civilian Pilot Assumes Command of Convoy.

HEADS SCHOOL BOARD

EARL RENAMED PRESIDENT OF SCHOOL BOARD

S. Rockwell Elected Vice President and C. A. Kvil Treasurer.

PRESBYTERIAN CHURCH FIRE LOSS $100,000

Third Downtown Religious Structure to Be Razed; Aggregate Damage $700,000.

BARE WALLS STANDING

Two Firemen Overcome by Smoke After Collapse of Roof.

CHURCH DESTROYED BY $100,000 FIRE

ASK STATE AID AFTER PRESBYTERIAN BLAZE

Flames Breaking Out at 11:20 p. m. Completely Destroy Structure at Rose and South Streets.

SET BY FIREBUG, BELIEF

Officials Promise Drastic Action to Apprehend Incendiary After Long Series of Fires.

FAIR SOUVENIR SLUGS LIKE COINS; BARRED

COOLIDGE SETS UP CAPITOL IN ADIRONDACKS

President and Party Arrive at Summer White House in Mountains.

ANDREWS DENIES HE INTENDS TO RESIGN

PROHIBIT PROPOSED "INSULT" TO U. S. FLAG

NOTED SPORTSMAN N.Y. PUBLISHER, DIES

NAB 10 IN INDIANA STREET CAR STRIKE

FLIER HOPS OFF ON JUMP ACROSS U. S.

APPROPRIATE $7,500 FOR STATE HOSPITAL

ASSAULTS DEPUTY; TO CELL 90 DAYS

COMPLETE PROBE OF PENNSY PRIMARIES

WEATHER VANE

Ayers He Saw Evangelist in Cafe 5 Days Before "Escape"

Hamilton Ayres as One of Party of Four; Says She Tried to Hide; Companion Corroborates Story.

First Presbyterian Church Second to Burn on Same Site

Building Just Destroyed in the 42 Years Since Frame Was Consumed by Fire in '83.

CAMPAIGN EXPENSES WILL BE DEM ISSUE

1925-1926

Kalamazoo Church Fires

an overview

Brian Ream

summary

Between December 1925 and July 1926

12 major fires in churches or meeting halls

Total damage - over $700,000 (over $22m 2024 dollars)

Destroyed First Congregational, First Methodist, and First Presbyterian Churches

CHURCHES

- East Avenue Methodist church (Dec. 17, the first of the series of church fires), $10,000.
- First Congregational church (complete loss), $175,000.
- First Presbyterian church (moving picture booth fire), $50.
- First Methodist church (complete loss), $100,000.
- First Presbyterian church (lobby fire), $250.
- First Presbyterian church (complete loss), $125,000.

LODGE HALLS

- Knights of Pythias temple (first fire in basement, small loss), $150.
- Knights of Pythias temple (second fire, heavy loss), $10,000.
- Chase block fire (Knights of Columbus quarters), $100,000.
- Moose temple (housing nine different lodges), $100,000.
- Trades and Labor Council hall, $10,000.
- Herfendahl store (housing four lodges), $8,000.

OTHERS

- Boudenman block, $10,000.
- Sutherland Paper Company (paraffin plant), $25,000.
- Macy's garage, $20,000.

The Fires

The Deaths

WALK OF HONOR®
SECTION C

BRICK NUMBER

MI-175

BRICK INSCRIPTION

JOHN MORREN

DOD MARCH 13, 1926

BRICK STATUS

PLACED

Emmitsburg, MD

13 Mar 1926 (aged 27)
Kalamazoo, Kalamazoo County, Michigan, USA
Riverside Cemetery
Kalamazoo, Kalamazoo County, Michigan, USA
PP 063,06
25874313 · View Source

Congregational - Origin unknown at first, but later blamed on an overheated boiler

Methodist - Overheated furnace or defective wiring

Presbyterian - Started in or near the pipe organ

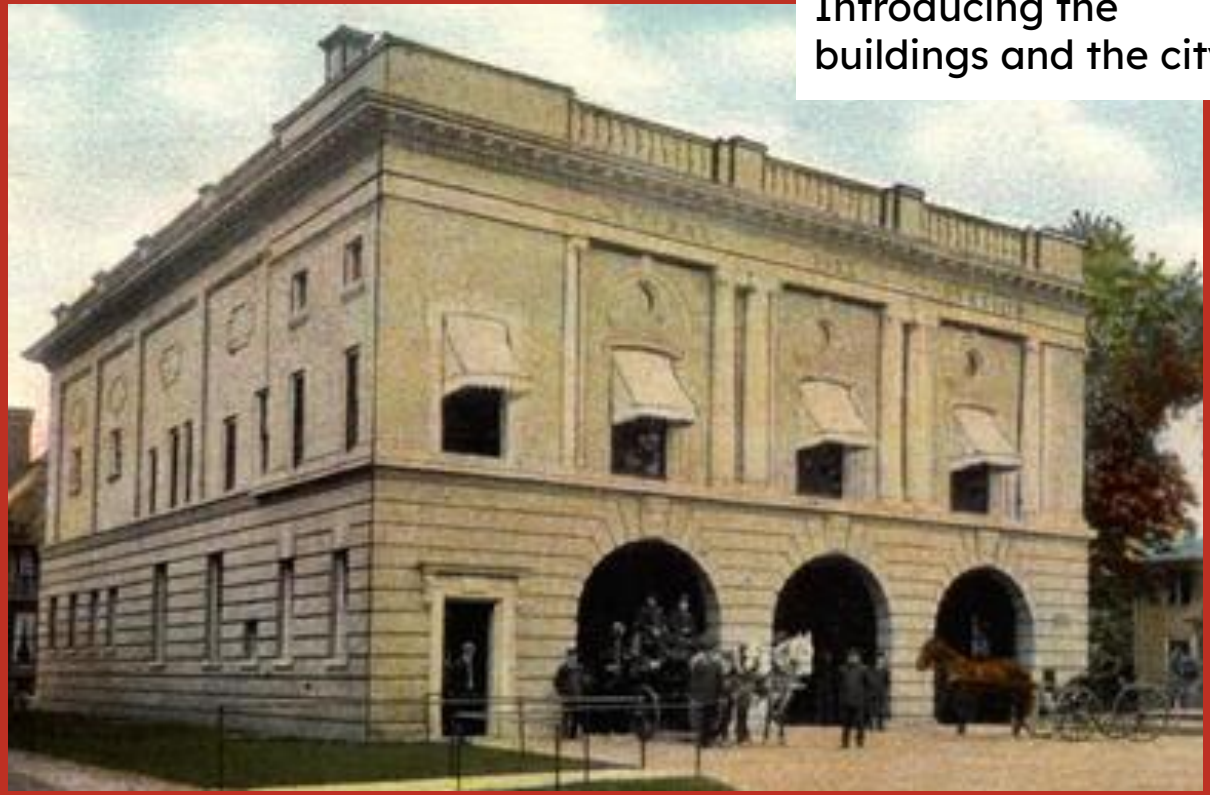
The Investigations

As a group, all fires were believed to be arson.

Rebuilding

timeline

Introducing the buildings and the city…



Central Fire was constructed in 1907 and was the station that served downtown until 1959. The fire chief during the church fires was Charles H. Russell.

First Congregational built this third church in 1890 in the church's current location. The congregants hated it and complained of the leaky roof among other issues.

First Presbyterian was scheduled to be replaced shortly before it burned.

First Methodist went through many changes over time for budgetary reasons and I’m not sure if this is the steeple of the church that burned.

After the fire in 1925, the church's time capsule was opened, containing a letter written by Rev. A. S. Kedzie.

He wrote, "There are in this village today six Protestant churches and a Catholic church. There is a Baptist church with one hundred seventy-six members; a Methodist with eighty members; St. Luke's with fifty members; a Dutch Reformed with sixty members; a Presbyterian with one hundred eighty, and the Congregational with one hundred sixty.

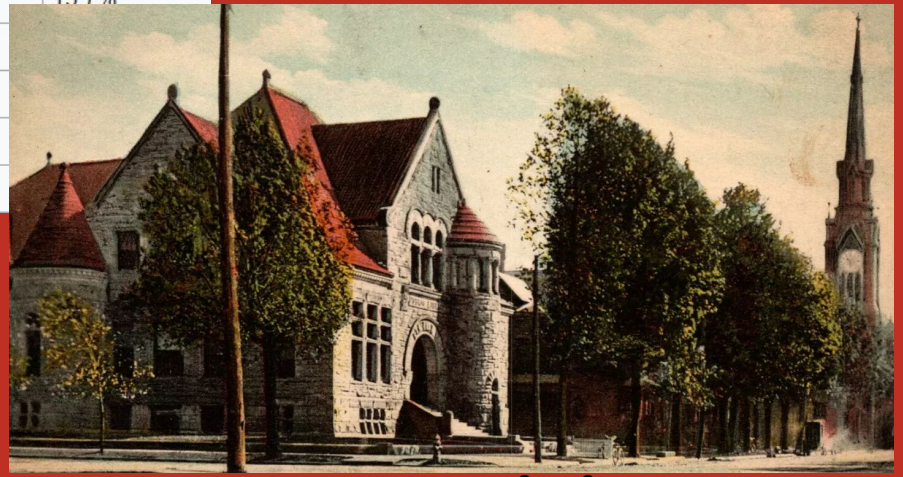
There are four common schools, one and sometimes two private schools, a Female Seminary, and a Baptist College and Theological Seminary, each in the early stages of their growth. How changed will be the conditions of this place (now numbering between three and four thousand inhabitants) and of this church when this shall be brought forth for the perusal of some distant generation. May He then look down from the heights of Heaven and see Freedom and Christianity over-spreading the earth."

Kalamazoo was proud its churches.

The following is a list of cities in Michigan with a population of at least 15,000 based on 1920 U.S. Census data. Historic census data from 1910 and 1930 is included to reflect trends in population increases or decreases.

1920 Rank	City	County	1910 Pop.	1920 Pop.	1930 Pop.	Change 1920-30
1	Detroit	Wayne	465,766	993,678	1,568,662	57.9%
2	Grand Rapids	Kent	112,571	137,634	168,592	22.5%
3	Flint	Genesee	38,550	91,599	156,492	70.8%
4	Saginaw	Saginaw	50,510	61,903	80,715	30.4%
5	Lansing	Ingham	31,229	57,327	78,397	36.8%
6	Hamtramck	Wayne	3,559	48,615	56,268	15.7%
7	Kalamazoo	Kalamazoo	39,437	48,487	54,786	
8	Jackson	Jackson	31,433	48,374	55,187	
9	Bay City	Bay	45,166	47,554	47,355	
10	Highland Park	Wayne	4,120	46,499	52,959	

The library and the Methodist Church



Construction on the Marlborough Building began in 1923. It is now on the national register of historic places. (May 1983)

Bronson Park evolved from a field for visitors to graze their animals to a central park.

The Majestic (Capitol) Theatre was built in 1907 and badly damaged by fire in 1923. Electricity was becoming more widely available at the time.

The entrance to First Congregational was always on Academy Street, even in the rebuilt church. It was moved to Michigan Avenue when the parking lot was constructed, whereas during the time of this church, Kalamazoo was selling over 1500 automobiles a year.

THE WEATHER
Cloudy Tuesday night and Wednesday; light snow; no decided change in temperature.

THE KALAMAZOO GAZETTE

LAST EDITION

NINETY-FOURTH YEAR—NO. 70. KALAMAZOO, MICH., U. S. A., TUESDAY, DECEMBER 29, 1925. 18 PAGES PRICE THREE CENTS

CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH BURNS

$175,000 STRUCTURE DESTROYED AT NOON

Starts Near Heating Plant; Boys Give Alarm; Adjacent Edifices Saved; Smoke Darkens City.

The First Congregational church, Park and Academy streets, one of Kalamazoo's oldest and most beautiful churches, was completely destroyed by fire, Tuesday noon, in one of the worst conflagrations that has visited this city in many years. The building was valued at $175,000. The loss was partly covered by $100,000 insurance.

The fire is believed to have started in the basement of the church, near the heating plant. C. E. Price, West Cedar street, the janitor, left the building at noon. Thirty minutes later the interior of the building was in flames.

BOYS DISCOVER FIRE.

Arthur Stoops, 312 John street, court, and John Triestram, 308 Boerman avenue, two boys, were passing the church on their way to the Y. M. C. A. when their attention was drawn by the cracking of glass in one of the windows on the main floor. Triestram dashed to the Y. M. C. A. and telephoned the fire department.

By the time the first fire companies reached the scene, heavy black smoke was rolling in great volumes from the basement windows on the east side of the building. As fast as the firemen arrived, more lines of three-inch hose were put into action and the men concentrated their efforts in pouring great streams of water into the basement, which they believed was the seat of the fire.

INTERIOR ROARING FURNACE

The fire was discovered at 12:25. At 1:05 p. m. the entire roof of the west wing of the church collapsed. Instantly the entire building was a roaring furnace within. Ten lines of hose were then pouring streams of water into the flames. Firemen had climbed to the fire escapes and roof of the Y. M. C. A. to the north in order to battle with the flames at a better advantage.

It was more than an hour, however, before they had the fire under control, and buildings immediately surrounding were saved. The First Reformed church is adjacent to the east and the Y. M. C. A. building and the First Baptist church stand a short distance away to the north.

TUESDAY, DECEMBER 29, 1925.

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SAVE NEARBY BUILDINGS.

The solid brick walls of the church withstood the fierceness of the roaring flames from within and kept the fire from spreading to the nearby building in spite of the fact that there was a slight breeze from the northwest.

Every available piece of fire apparatus in the city was summoned after the call had been received at Central fire station. Many firemen who were off duty for the day were called back into the service.

FLAME LEAPS FROM ROOF.

Several pipemen, among the first to reach the fire managed to work their way through the dense smoke into the basement of the building, but it was so suffocating they were unable to remain inside but a few moments. While they were pouring the water into the basement windows to the east, someone suddenly discovered a tongue of flame leaping from the peak of the roof.

More hose was called into play and firemen climbed to points of vantage in an effort to head off the flames. By this time, however, the main auditorium of the church was in flames and the holes which broke through the roof opened the disastrous draft which the firemen had hoped to prevent.

ESTABLISH FIRE LINES.

Hundreds of people who were on the streets during the noon hour were attracted to the scene by the great volumes of yellow-black smoke which swept low into the streets in the business section, darkening the entire city. Fire lines had to be strung and the crowds were held back in safety, as it was feared the big walls might collapse at any moment. Firebrands dropped like snowflakes all over the business district.

The big brick tower of the church remained standing throughout the fire, although it made the work of the firemen extremely hazardous, as it was feared it might topple over at any moment.

TONS OF WATER USED.

The flames, it is believed, swept through the entire building by following the furnace pipes and ventilating system. The tons of water that were poured into the flames finally conquered the blaze.

When the general alarm was sounded engine companies No. 1, 2, 4, 5, and 6 responded with full apparatus and No. 3 company from the East Side was drawn into Central station to stand ready for other emergencies.

BUILT IN 1890.

The Congregational church, which is the largest Protestant church structure in Kalamazoo, was erected in 1890, replacing the first church originally built on the same site nearly 50 years before. The contract for the new church was awarded to Glanfield and Son, builders, who came to Kalamazoo and secured in rapid succession contracts for erection of the original Y. M. C. A. building, the Congregational church, and the People's church.

The Congregational structure was ornate in design with a tower at the southeast entrance. The exterior was largely of Marquette red stone, veneered around a heavy timbered interior. In addition to the church auditorium proper, the edifice contained a prayer meeting room, large parlors, kitchen, and pastor's study. The interior arrangement was such that many drafts and cross currents were formed, adding to the difficulty in fighting the fire.

The building as it stands today represents an outlay of about $175,000. It was built at a time when material and building wages were at the lowest price. Since the original construction, many minor changes have been made in the edifice, though in the main it stands today as originally planned.

The present pastor is the Rev. Torrance T. Phelps. The congregation numbers about 1,000 and includes in its enrollment many of the most prominent business and professional men of the community.

Before the fire was under control, the trustees of the People's church formally offered use of their building to the Congregational church as a temporary home.

WEDNESDAY, DECEMBER 30, 1925.

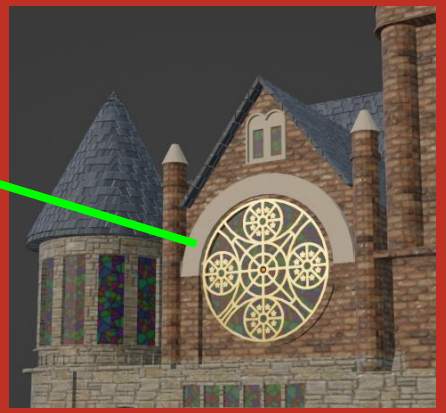
RUINS OF WHAT WAS LARGEST PROTESTANT CHURCH IN CITY

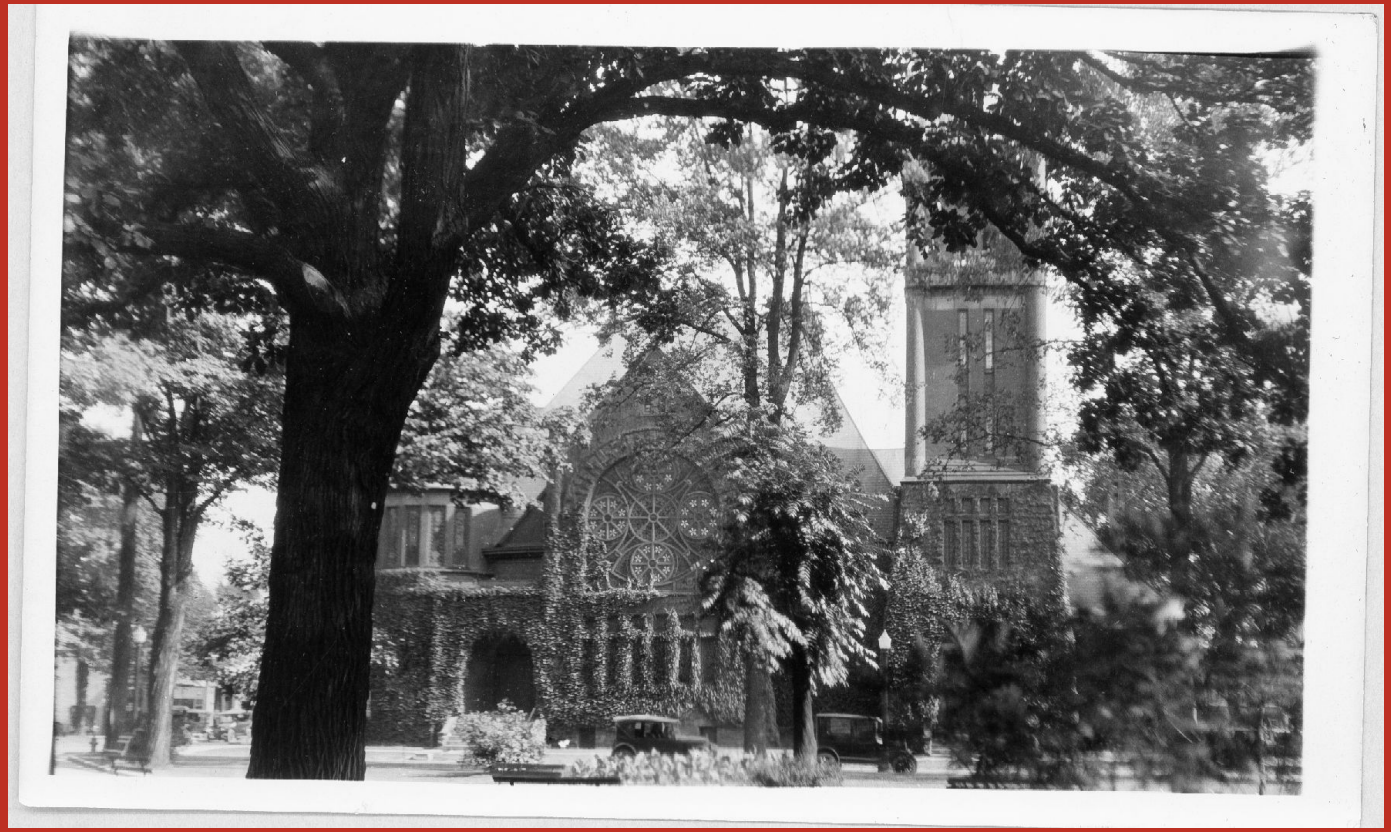
—Photo by H. A. Young Studio.

rear. Camera was directed at po er entrance showing few of unbur ned pews at rear. Camera was directed at position occupied by p ulpit.

WEDNESDAY, DECEMBER 30, 1925.

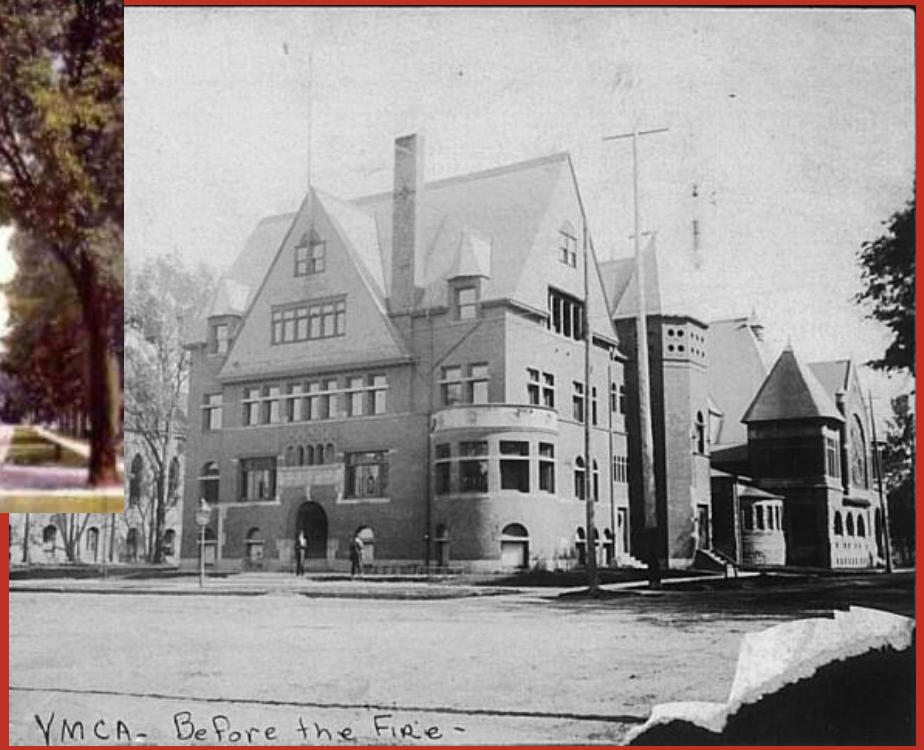
View from First Reformed church yard, looking west through skeleton of old Congregational church, showing undamaged tower at extreme left. —Photo by H. A. Young Studio.





FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH, KALAMAZOO, MICH.

First Congregational Church and Academy Street


YMCA- Before the Fire-

First Congregational Church, Academy Street, Kalamazoo, c1885-1889 Kalamazoo Public Library Photograph P-351

THE WEATHER
Generally fair Sunday. Not much change in temperature.

THE KALAMAZOO GAZETTE

LAST EDITION

NINETY FOURTH YEAR—NO. 145. MEMBER ASSOCIATED PRESS KALAMAZOO, MICH., U. S. A., SUNDAY, MARCH 14, 1926. MEMBER OF UNITED PRESS ASSOCIATIONS. 30 PAGES PRICE FIVE CENTS.

2 DIE IN M. E. CHURCH FIRE

TWO FIREMEN AND BURNING CHURCH IN WHICH THEY MET DEATH

Fire scene photo by H. A. Youngs Studio

The fire was discovered at 6:00 p. m. and, although the church is within a block of Central Fire station, the entire roof was enveloped in flames before the firemen could reach the scene. Every available piece of fire apparatus in the city was thrown into action. All firemen off duty were called into service and Kalamazoo's entire force of firemen were swiftly into service.

The fire is believed to have started in the south end of the basement of the church and was due either to an overheated furnace or to defective wiring, in the opinion of Fire Chief Charles H. Russell.

BATTLE FLAMES AN HOUR.

For nearly an hour the firemen battled with the flames from all sides, the blaze being too fierce for the men to enter the building. Thousands of tons of water were thrown into the flames, but the fire had gained such headway during the first few minutes that it was soon out of control. Frame buildings to the south and east of the church were saved from destruction by being drenched with a continuous downpour of water.

The fire was virtually under control when the tragedy which snuffed out the lives of two of Kalamazoo's most popular firemen occurred.

They had been sent in as a relief squad to firemen who had battled with the blaze from the start.

Grasping a line of hose Slater and Morren, in company with Firemen Ben Kruizenga, Martin Leyden, and others, entered the main entrance to the church to play water on the burning ruins inside. They had reached the second doors which open directly into the church proper and had passed through the west doorway to a distance of about five feet.

As the three men were holding the line of hose, others, who had moved about six feet to one side, heard a crash above and noticed the roof of the second balcony—about 40 feet in the air, give way. They called to their companions to "run for your lives," and dashed to the door. Leyden, thought to have been the nearest to the door, just crossed the threshold as the falling brick and timbers crashed to the floor. Kruisenga and one or two other firemen also reached safety, but not before falling brick had struck their feet.

SUNDAY, MARCH 14, 1926.

1 of 2

summary | timeline | deaths | investigations | rebuilding

MEC

ICE SAVES TWO HOUSES.

A dozen streams of hose forced water on virtually every portion of the building, some wetting down the side walls, others crashing through the windows to the interior and two playing on the home of Frank Russell, directly east of the church and that of A. H. Rothermel, directly south of the structure. Fear was expressed for the safety of both these homes as the flames and firebrands were shooting in the direction of both. The Rothermel home is located about 10 feet from the rear of the church while the Russell home is about a rod and a half away. Ice forming on the roofs of these two homes probably saved them from catching fire.

The church burned with great rapidity. Just one hour after the fire was discovered, the building was in total ruins. The roof had caved in and nothing stood but the bare brick walls. Wooden cornices at the tops of the walls burned and a fiery border circled the top. Luckily, none of the four walls collapsed, but policemen roped off fire limits to protect the thousands of people who thronged about the corner to watch the fire.

FIREMEN SEE BLAZE FIRST.

Dense smoke clouded the entire neighborhood. Firemen at Central station, just one block away, saw the smoke as it issued from the top of the structure and thus received the alarm. Just as the department was responding an alarm came in from D. S. Field.

Every piece of fire apparatus in the city was pressed into service, and pumpers and trucks were stationed at every corner within a radius of one block from the church. Six pumpers forced a maximum of 6,000 gallons of water a minute on the fire.

Seven thousand feet of hose were put into use, more than a dozen lines being extended from the pumpers. Every fireman in the city, including all reserves, were called into service and fought the flames for more than three hours. Water was poured onto the burning ruins for two hours following the crashing of the roof.

2 of 2

SUNDAY, MARCH 14, 1926.

THREE LINES OF HOSE BURST.

Three different lines of hose burst during the fire, which further handicapped the firemen. These breakages were caused, Chief Russell stated, from excess pressure of the pumps.

Street car traffic was at a standstill during the fire, as power on the trolley wires had to be cut to make it possible for firemen to direct streams of water on the flames from the Rose street side.

As night fell and the temperature lowered, the firemen became ice-coated and soaked from the spray of water. The streets around the church were flooded to a depth of one to three inches with water.

The walls of the church stood like ghostly spectres with a white coating of ice and trees near the structure sparkled with frozen spray from the hose lines.

Frank Russell, who conducts a boarding house just east of the church, immediately opened his home to the firemen and prepared coffee and food for the firemen. Other citizens sent sandwiches and a number of city employes went to Central station and prepared coffee, which was carried to the fighters.

Four Kalamazoo Churches Ignited in Three Months

First Methodist Blaze Fifth Serious Visitation of Kind in City During Same Period.

Saturday's blaze was the fifth bad fire which has occurred in Kalamazoo within the last three months. It was the fourth church fire in Kalamazoo during the same period.

December 29, the First Congregational church was destroyed by a fire which threatened to sweep several nearby structures. The loss was estimated at $175,000. It was partly covered by insurance. Two weeks prior to this blaze, the East Avenue M. E. church was visited by fire which caused about $5,000 damage.

Closely following the Congregational church blaze, the Knights of Pythias building in East South street was swept by fire. The damage was estimated at $10,000. Scores of people in the building at the time the fire broke out were forced to leave by the fire escapes.

January 26 the heart of Kalamazoo's business district was threatened when the Chase block at Main and Rose streets burst into flames shortly after 7:00 a. m. Firemen battled for nearly three hours with the stubborn fire which virtually gutted the entire building, which was four stories high. The loss ran more than $100,000.

Last Sunday morning's fire caused $5,000 damage to the Boudeman building, South Burdick street. The blaze started on the ground floor and had gained dangerous headway into upper floors when it was discovered.

summary | timeline | deaths | investigations | rebuilding

SATURDAY, APRIL 10, 1926.

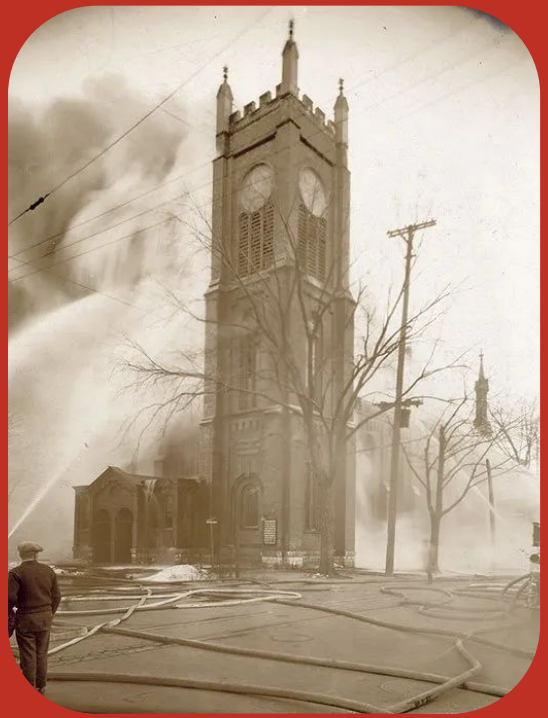


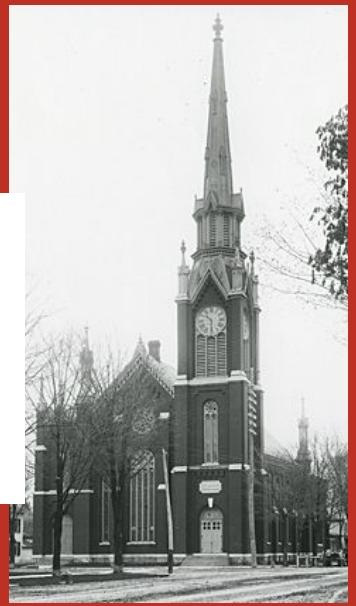
Photo from Lynn Houghton - Encore

METHODIST CHURCH TO BE TORN DOWN

PLANS BEING DRAWN FOR NEW EDIFICE AT ACADEMY AND PARK STREETS.

Demolition of the ruins of the First Methodist church structure at Lovell and Rose streets is to be started at once. Trustees of the church have advertised for bids. C. A. Krill, chairman of the board, says no steps will be taken toward the erection of the new church until the return of the Rev. D. Stanley Coors, pastor. He is now in the West, but is expected home early in May. Ernest Batterson, local architect, is preparing preliminary sketches for the new church, which will be erected at the Academy and Park street site. Mr. Krill reports minor differences pertaining to fire insurance have been worked out and adjusted and that a settlement of the insurance will follow in a few days.

(Work began on the new edifice in 1865 and the sanctuary was completed in 1869. Due to fundraising limitations, the planned tower and steeple were not added until 1873. - KPL)



WEDNESDAY, JUNE 2, 1926.

FIFTH CHURCH FIRE CAUSES $500 LOSS

BURNING OF PEWS LAID TO CIGARET; SERVICES NOT TO BE INTERRUPTED.

For the fifth time in as many months, fire Tuesday night visited a church in Kalamazoo. The blaze was fought for 30 minutes when it was extinguished, leaving a damage of $500.

The blaze started in the main lobby of the First Presbyterian church, Rose and South streets, less than an hour after Masons had vacated the building after a banquet. A carelessly tossed cigaret stub is believed responsible.

Firemen and apparatus from stations 1, 4, and 6 responded to the alarm at 9:07. Smoke curled through the crevices between the large doors as firemen whipped out their hose lines. The blaze was soon under control.

Several pews were burned or scorched, but there was no other damage from the flames, which were confined to the few square yards in which they originated. Most of the damage was from water thrown by the firemen.

The Presbyterian church was threatened with destruction when a fire started in the motion picture booth several months ago. Tuesday night's church fire brought the number to five since last December when the East Avenue M. E. church was damaged. The second also occurred in December when the First Congregational church was razed. A small fire in the Presbyterian church was third and the First Methodist fire last March was fourth.

Services planned for the church building will be carried on without interruption, it was stated Wednesday by officials after an inspection of the building.

THE WEATHER
Fair Wednesday and probably Thursday; warmer, Thursday.

THE KALAMAZOO GAZETTE

LAST EDITION

NINETY-FOURTH YEAR—NO. 260. MEMBER ASSOCIATED PRESS KALAMAZOO, MICH., U. S. A., WEDNESDAY, JULY 7, 1926. MEMBER OF UNITED PRESS ASSOCIATIONS 20 PAGES PRICE THREE CENTS.

PROBING NEW CHURCH FIRE

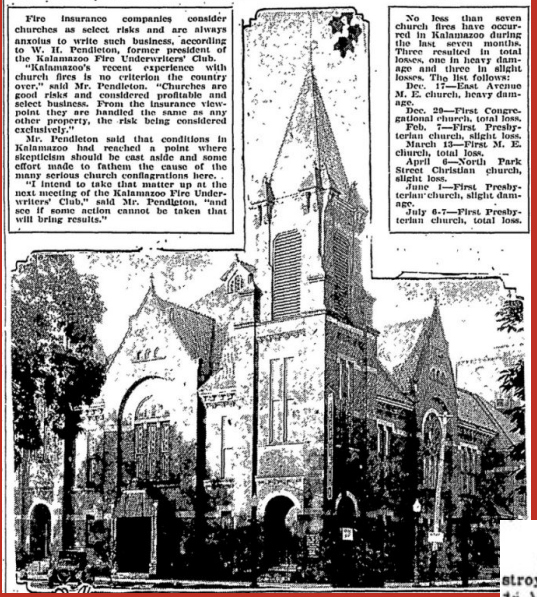
CHURCH DESTROYED BY $100,000 FIRE

Fire insurance companies consider churches as select risks and are always anxious to write such business, according to W. H. Pendleton, former president of the Kalamazoo Fire Underwriters' Club.

"Kalamazoo's recent experience with church fires is no criterion the country over," said Mr. Pendleton. "Churches are good risks and considered profitable and select business. From the insurance viewpoint they are handled the same as any other property, the risk being considered exclusively."

Mr. Pendleton said that conditions in Kalamazoo had reached a point where skepticism should be cast aside and some effort made to fathem the cause of the many serious church conflagrations here.

"I intend to take that matter up at the next meeting of the Kalamazoo Fire Underwriters' Club," said Mr. Pendleton, "and see if some action cannot be taken that will bring results."



No less than seven church fires have occurred in Kalamazoo during the last seven months. Three resulted in total losses, one in heavy damage and three in slight losses. The list follows:

Dec. 17—East Avenue M. E. church, heavy damage.

Dec. 29—First Congregational church, total loss.

Feb. 7—First Presbyterian church, slight loss.

March 13—First M. E. church, total loss.

April 6—North Park Street Christian church, slight loss.

June 1—First Presbyterian church, slight damage.

July 6-7—First Presbyterian church, total loss.

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July 6-7—First Presbyterian church, total loss.

FIRST PRESBYTERIAN CHURCH.

This beautiful structure which stood at South and Rose streets, is in ruins today. It was destroyed by a $100,000 fire which gutted the structure and ruined the walls. The building was dedicated 42 years ago and was one of the city's leading churches. The loss is partly covered by insurance.

WEDNESDAY, JULY 7, 1926.

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PRESBYTERIAN CHURCH FIRE LOSS $100,000

Two Firemen Overcome by Smoke After Collapse of Roof.

DISCOVERED AT 11:20

The Presbyterian fire was discovered about 11:20 when the entire interior of the auditorium burst forth in flames. Some of the flames shot out the windows with the first puff.

While apparatus from Central station a block away was responding to the alarm, patrolmen at the scene broke open the front doors that firemen might carry hose lines into the structure with the least possible delay. Smoke filled every room in the structure and the crackling of the flames could be heard from the street. Fire limits were immediately established by the police and the work of fighting another big church fire got under way within five minutes after the alarm had sounded.

BURSTS INTO FLAME.

The fire, which was the most spectacular of the church conflagrations to watch, is said to have started in or near the pipe organ at the rear of the pulpit.

Patrolman Clare Stevens, who turned in the alarm, was the first person to discover the fire. He stated that suddenly the entire interior of the auditorium seemed to burst forth in flames, where a second before all had been darkness. Sergeant John Sperry of the police department saw the first spurt of flames two blocks away.

Upon arrival at the church, Chief Charles H. Russell and several men from Central station started inside the building through the front entrance. They saw the flames as they shot toward the ceiling in the rear of the auditorium and they sought to fight them at close range. Just as they entered the main auditorium plaster began falling and the smoke began to thicken. So fierce became the roaring furnace and great the possibility of injury or death from falling ceiling that Chief Russell and his men retreated from the building.

It was while inside the church at the very beginning of the fire that the two firemen, A. C. VanHaaften and Gaare DeRight, were almost overcome by smoke. They were helped from the building by other firemen and after a rest of a few moments were unable to resume their posts.

The church building burned with fierceness and great rapidity. The entire structure lay in ruins one hour after the fire was discovered and between the time the fire flames were noticed by Officer Stevens and the time the department from Central station arrived the entire rear portion of the auditorium and the pipe organ had been ignited.

The flames leaped ceilingward from the pipe organ and soon caught to the beams and began coursing toward the front of the building. Fifteen minutes after the alarm the entire front portion of the roof burst into flames. The tongues of fire leaped high into the air and sent firebrands sailing over the roofs of the downtown buildings.

ROOF CRASHES.

The front portion of the roof burned rapidly and just a few moments before it fell into the mass of ruins the rear portion of the roof burst into flame. The roof the First Presbyterian church seemed to burn more rapidly than the roofs of other churches. The firemen were unable to quell the flames on the roof, despite the fact that six different lines of hose were playing water on the top of the building. As the two sections of the church roof fell, a great, resounding puff, not unlike a stifled explosion, was heard and the flames from the interior of the building shot high into the air, while huge firebrands hurtled from the inside ruins over the jagged shell of the walls. Startled by the crash, the crowds started a sudden rush away from the building, fearing that the walls might fall.

After the roof had fallen the firemen gradually subdued the flames on the inside. Seeing it would be impossible to save the structure itself, Chief Russell concentrated all his efforts in saving the adjoining buildings from igniting. A line of hose was strung to the top floor of the Pythian building, located just ten feet east of the presbyterian church, while another line was carried to the roof of the Y. W. C. A. Lines of water manned from the ground were used intermittently to wet the sides of the adjoining buildings which faced the fire.

The walls of the Y. W. C. A. north of the church in South Rose street, became so heated that a person could not bear his hand against them. The windows in the west side of the Pythian building were either broken or cracked by the heat. Eight of 10 men who were in the Pythian building, under the leadership of Ralph Chapman, climbed to the fire escape on the west side of the building and wet down the east roof of the church building with fire extinguishers and hose lines from the interior of the Pythian block. When the heat became too intense, these men returned inside the building and poured chemicals from the windows.

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Fear was freely expressed that the Pythian building, which has been on fire two different times within the last eight months, might be ignited by the flames from the church fire and every precaution was taken to warn every one in the building of the danger. Officers made a tour of every floor of the building as soon as the church fire started and people who have offices in the building were notified, that they might take from their offices as much of value as they could, pending a possible outbreak in the Pythian building.

Guests, officials, and employes at the Y. W. C. A. building were routed from their sleep by firemen and officers and all of the occupants were ordered downstairs in the main lobby. The Y. W. C. A., however, was in less danger of ignition than the Pythian building, due to the fact that the light breeze carried the flames in an opposite direction.

The lives of Chief Russell and six of his firemen were endangered when a large section of the west portion of the roof loosened and came crashing to the street on the south side of the building. The chief and his men were engaged at the time, and were in a group in moving two or three hose lines about 15 feet from the south wall. As the section of the roof started to slide the crowd of spectators cried out and the firemen, looking up, saw the oncoming shower of bricks and timbers. They made a wild dash for safety and reached the center of the street just as the debris struck the ground. Loosened slates from the roof and bricks and heavy pieces of charred wood were raining down continuously during the fire, endangering the firemen and makeing it difficult to move the hose lines close to the building.

After the fire had abated to some extent, the front entrance of the church was opened and two lines of hose forced water into the southwest spire, saving it from being gutted. The same move was made in the northwest spire and that section was also saved from complete ruin.

The entire downtown section of the city and residence areas for many blocks away were clouded with smoke from the fire and during the time the flames were at their height the reflection could be seen many mils away from the city. Although there was not a heavy breeze Tuesday night, firebrands were thrown high into the air and were carried as far as a block away.

The fire started at 11:20 and at 2:45 the smoke and fire had cleared away to expose jagged walls of smoke-black brick, with charred timbers, twisted iron rods, and debris leaning in hap-hazard effect outside the structure. Inside was a mass of twisted, smoking ruins which about three hours before had been a part of the city's largest church building. The interior of the auditorium was a complete loss and virtually every other portion of the building was damaged beyond remodeling. The southeastern section fared the best during the fire, and although the roof was burned and fell inside, the interior did not burst forth into flames

Seeing it would be impossible to save the interior of the church, following the first attempt of firemen to enter the building, Chief Russell issued strict orders that no one was to enter the burning building. When a detail of firemen started with a hose line toward the front entrance, Chief Russell ordered them away. He would not permit his men to go through the doors of the gutted structure until dawn, and he himself surveyed the smouldering ruins from the top floor and roof of the Pythian block, just 10 feet away. The chief took every precaution to protect the lives of his men and, for three hours after the flames had died down the firemen remained on the outside to play the streams of water.

(KPL)

deaths

FALLING BALCONY CRUSHES FIREMEN

Claus Slater and John Morren Buried Under Tons of Debris After Flames Had Been Placed Under Control.

FIVE OTHERS INJURED FIGHTING BLAZE

Loss, Estimated at $100,000, Only Half Covered by Insurance; Chief Russell in Tears Over Tragedy.

JOHN MORREN.

CLAUS SLATER.

SUNDAY, MARCH 14, 1926.

FIVE FIREMEN INJURED IN M. E. CHURCH BLAZE

JAMES RAVEN

"PAT" THOMAS

BEN KRUZENGA

ONLY ONE OF THE FIVE INJURED FIREMEN WAS SERIOUSLY HURT. HE WAS CAUGHT WITH SLATER AND MORREN IN COLLAPSE OF THE BALCONY, BUT WAS AN INSTANT SOONER THAN THEY IN TRYING TO RUSH TO SAFETY AFTER THEY SAW THE SOUTH WALL OF THE TOWER WAS FALLING.

C. C. CHANNELLS

FRANK CHICHESTER

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THE DEAD.

Pipeman John Morren, 35, No. 5 engine house, residence 1010 Douglas avenue.

Driver Claus Slater, 32, No. 1 engine house, residence Lumm avenue.

THE INJURED.

Driver Benjamin Kruizenga, No. 1 engine house, 1357 North Edwards street. Cuts and bruised about the head and face. Taken home.

Pipeman James Raven, No. 1 engine house, 416 East Walnut street, leg broken and body injured. Taken to Old Borgess hospital.

Driver C. C. Channels, No. 3 engine house, 620 Charlotte avenue, injured about the knees and arms. Taken home.

Pipeman Patrick A. Thomas, No. 3 engine house, 1208 Hays Park avenue, injured about the head. Taken to Central fire station for medical attention.

Lieut. Frank Chichester, No. 3 engine house, 136 South Burdick street, injured about the legs. Taken to Central fire station for medical attention.

RECOVERED IN TWO HOURS.

It was nearly two hours before the bodies of the dead firemen were finally dug from the ruins. The rescuers worked in shifts.

METHODIST CHURCH FIRE AT A GLANCE

Two firemen killed by falling roof.

Five firemen injured — one seriously.

Entire church gutted and ruined in one hour.

Firemen at Central station "turned in own alarm" when they saw smoke issuing from the church.

Nearly two hours were required to extricate bodies of two dead firemen.

Was first fire to take lives since Hall Brothers blaze in 1907.

Seven thousand feet of hose were used to force 6,000 gallons of water per minute on the ruins.

Roof fell 30 minutes after fire started.

Was fourth church fire in four months.

Loss was estimated at $100,000. Insurance believed to be about $50,000.

Five thousand people watched the fire, according to estimates.

Two Kalamazoo firemen were killed and five others were injured Saturday evening in a fire which swept the First Methodist church at Rose and Lovell streets to complete ruin. The loss is estimated at $100,000.

The firemen met death when they were caught beneath a falling balcony at the north end of the church. The balcony fell in as the south side of the big brick tower gave way. Tons of brick and heavy beams came down upon the heads of the firemen almost without warning. Those who escaped barely managed to reach the front vestibule door. Others were caught underneath the wreckage and were helpless until rescued by fellow firemen.

As the three men were holding the line of hose, others, who had moved about six feet to one side, heard a crash above and noticed the roof of the second balcony—about 40 feet in the air, give way. They called to their companions to "run for your lives," and dashed to the door. Leyden, thought to have been the nearest to the door, just crossed the threshold as the falling brick and timbers crashed to the floor. Kruisenga and one or two other firemen also reached safety, but not before falling brick had struck their feet.

Slater and Morren did not reach the door. Both men had gotten within a foot of safety when their bodies were carried through the floor to a depth of two feet. They both fell within a few inches of each other and were undoubtedly crushed to death.

FORMS RESCUE SQUAD.

The first inkling firemen on the outside of the building had of disaster was when Leyden and the others rushed out shouting that their two companions had been buried beneath the falling roof. Chief Russell immediately organized a rescue party and a dozen firemen and policemen, armed with axes, shovels and lanterns, invaded the building, imperiling their own lives as portions of the roof and sections of the brick walls were still sliding to the main floor. No signs of the two firemen could be found at first.

Firemen, policemen, and officers from the sheriff's department began digging, throwing out the timbers and debris as fast as they could. They were severely handicapped for a moment by the high-powered streams of water which were still being played on the ruins and also by darkness. A big searchlight was wired up by Sheriff Borden and suspended over the workmen.

FIND FIRST BODY.

The rescuers dug to a depth of one foot before any trace of either firemen was found. Then one shovel struck the leather-coated body of Slater. "I've found one body," informed a fireman. Then they started work with their hands, heaving away the bricks and other debris until half the buried fireman's body was uncovered. He was lying face downward. The firemen thought it would be but a few moments before the body would be unearthed but it required exactly one hour and 10 minutes to extricate the body of the first victim. A huge timber had lodged across his limbs and firemen had to cut this away with axes. Care had to be used to avoid striking the body and the firemen who were doing the work were in constant danger of plunging through the floor to the basement. It was necessary for three firemen to hold the body of Slater to keep it from sinking head-downward to the basement.

FELL FACE DOWNWARD.

Finally the body was freed and was carried to the H. S. Harrington morgue in the police ambulance. At that time the body of Morren had not been found. Digging to the eastward of the place where Slater's body had been found, firemen located Morren's body, buried deep in the debris. He, too, had fallen face downward, having been struck just as he was about to pass through the doorway. Less difficulty was experienced in extricating Morren's body and this gruesome task was completed in half an hour. His body was taken to the Harrington morgue.

CHIEF RUSSELL WEEPS.

Tears coursed down the fire blackened cheeks of Chief Russell, who had battled the flames for more than an hour and who had warned all his men to be careful in entering the building, when the bodies of Slater and Morren were extricated from the ruins.

"Brave men and good firemen," was his exclamation in a broken voice. "We read of these things happenings in other cities every day but when a tragedy of this kind strikes home, it is a different matter." He stated that the men who entered the shell of the building took their lives in their hands, but added further that he had not ordered them so far into the building. If they had fought the burning ruins from the doorway of the first lobby they would not have been killed, he stated.

The bodies of the firemen were lying across the hose which they had been operating.

had been operating.

MEMBER OF FIREMEN'S BAND.

Slater had been in the fire department about a year, the chief stated, and was driver of the hook and ladder truck at Central station. He was also prominent and popular in the firemen's band and was well-liked by his companions. He leaves a wife and three children.

Morren was stationed at Number 5 station in Douglas avenue and had been in the department two years. He was married last June. He leaves two children by a former wife, who died.

James Raven was injured when he entered the basement at the rear to locate the blaze. It is believed he fell, severely injuring one knee. He was carried from the burning building by companions and taken to Old Borgess hospital in the police car.

TWO NEARLY SUFFOCATED.

The other injured firemen sustained their cuts and bruises while fighting the fire from within. Two of the men were nearly suffocated.

The church building was empty of firemen when the roof caved in.

When firemen reached the scene, the church was virtually obscured by smoke which spread in clouds from every window and crevice. They were handicapped by the density of smoke and those men entering the basement and other portions of the building were required to wear gas masks.

The fire was located in the basement at the rear of the church as soon as firemen arrived. At that time it had reached nearly to the roof at the back end, before hose could be played on all parts of the building, the roof had blazed forth. It was seen then by Chief Russell that the building would go in spite of any efforts his men could make. He ordered the firemen not to enter the building.

ICE SAVES TWO HOUSES.

A dozen streams of hose forced water on virtually every portion of the building, some wetting down the side walls, others crashing through the windows to the interior and two playing on the home of Frank Russell, directly east of the church and that of A. H. Rothermel, directly south of the structure. Fear was expressed for the safety of both these homes as the flames and firebrands were shooting in the direction of both. The Rothermel home is located about 10 feet from the rear of the church while the Russell home is about a rod and a half away. Ice forming on the roofs of these two homes probably saved them from catching fire.

catching fire.

The church burned with great rapidity. Just one hour after the fire was discovered, the building was in total ruins. The roof had caved in and nothing stood but the bare brick walls. Wooden cornices at the tops of the walls burned and a fiery border circled the top. Luckily, none of the four walls collapsed, but policemen roped off fire limits to protect the thousands of people who thronged about the corner to watch the fire.

SUNDAY, MARCH 14, 1926.

"BRAVE MEN AND GOOD FIREMEN."

To describe yesterday evening's tragedy as a profound shock to Kalamazoo is to express all too mildly the reaction which the people of this city feel toward the loss of two of their bravest and manliest fellow-citizens. We do not wish to indulge in tritely phrased eulogies nor sing a requiem of flowery words, yet we do feel that the highest tribute is not too much to pay to men who have themselves paid their lives as the price of devotion to duty. As Chief Russell put it, we read of these things happening every day in other cities, but when a tragedy of this kind strikes home it is a different matter. And so it is. The fire department annals of many American communities contain accounts of courageous deeds and heroic sacrifices made by the men who are "always ready", but it takes something closer home to make us fully appreciate the true significance of the fireman's code of honor.

The destruction of the First Methodist Church edifice, famous landmark and venerable house of worship though it was, is all but obscured by the inestimably greater loss which its burning entailed. We are certain that the officers and members of the church will be among the first to recognize this. For there is something in the story of John Morren and Claus Slater which gives us new assurance that the world still has men who do not hesitate to hazard their lives in pursuance of their duties, that loyalty to the highest human principles may be sealed as bravely in peace as in war, and that the so-called "softening" influences of modern civilization have not deprived society of men who can face danger as men should.

Heroes? We could go on forever if we wished to argue the question of what constitutes a hero. But we don't think it is necessary to quibble over that. When men are literally struck down in the line of duty there is no reason whatever to be the least bit niggardly with the praise we ascribe to them. "Brave men and good firemen" was Chief Russell's brief but thoroughly sufficient comment; we will let it go at that and call it the finest tribute which any commander can pay to those who have served under him. Surely John Morren and Claus Slater would regard it as such. So would the five others who faced death with them in the treacherous recesses of the burning structure.

Kalamazoo is justly proud of John Morren and Claus Slater. But we are certain that even this great feeling of pride is far outshadowed by deep and genuine sympathy for the wives and children who bear the real brunt of yesterday's tragic happening. No words of comfort or consolation can soften more than slightly the anguish of their trial; no eulogies of the dead can help them bear a loss so bitter. We only hope that their spirits may be strengthened by the knowledge that the men they mourn died as men. And it is not to be thought, for one moment, that the people of Kalamazoo will allow the bereaved ones to endure any kind of suffering which it is within the people's power to prevent.

BURY JOHN MORREN WITH FULL HONORS

CITY PAYS TRIBUTE TO SECOND FIREMEN WHO DIED IN CHURCH BLAZE.

Honor was paid the memory of John Morren, fireman, second victim of the First Methodist church fire Saturday night, at funeral services at 2:00 Wednesday from the Third Christian Reformed church, Park and Walnut streets.

Kalamazoo people paused again Wednesday afternoon to pay a last tribute to a man who gave his life in the performance of his duty as firemen and to express sympathy to the widowed mother and three children.

City and county delegations, club and lodge representations and visiting Metropolitan clubs from several Michigan cities that attended the funeral services of Claus Slater, companion of Morren and a victim of the church fire, Tuesday afternoon, were present at the Morren services. The city hall remained closed from 12:00 to 4:00 in honor to the man and Mayor George K. Taylor and City Manager Ross J. Buck headed the delegation of city officials and employes that attended the funeral.

The Rev. John P. Battema, pastor of the Third Christian Reformed church, officiated at the Morren rites. There was prayer and music.

The body of John Morren had an escort of firemen and policemen as guards of honor, the same as the Slater remains. These guards formed about the casket in the church and marched with it to the funeral car. The body was escorted from the funeral car to the grave by these guards.

The funeral parade today was composed of virtually the same organizations that marched in memory of Claus Slater, yesterday. City firemen were present in a body and led delegations from upward of seven different Michigan cities. About two hundred firemen and policemen appeared in line.

Although the Morren services were not to begin until 2:00, the church was filled to capacity by 1:30, as was the case at the Slater funeral in the First Baptist church Tuesday. Scores of people were obliged to wait out-of-doors in the cold at the Slater funeral.

WEDNESDAY, MARCH 17, 1926.

SUNDAY, JUNE 13, 1926.

MEMORIAL WILL BE HELD FOR FIREMEN

RELIEF ASSOCIATION TO HOLD SERVICES THIS MORNING AT 9:00.

list of deceased members, the Firemen's Relief Association of Kalamazoo will observe its anunal memorial services at 9:00 Sunday forenoon at the grave of Claus Slater, one of the two firemen killed in the First Methodist church fire last yinter.

The Rev. Emanuel Rushbook, chaplain of the Kalamazoo association, will have charge of the services. There will be a sermon and appropriate music. Graves of the dead firemen will be decorated.

THE BEST REWARD FOR VALOR.

Whether or not the children of Claus Slater and John Morren will be given an education like other boys and girls is a question which the people of Kalamazoo must answer —and answer soon. The appeal made in their behalf by the local underwriters' club ought to receive a most generous popular response. We doubt if there were ten people in this entire city last Sunday morning who did not express, either audibly or to themselves, a noble desire to "do something" for the families of the two firemen whose unselfish devotion to duty cost them their lives in the First Methodist Church fire. The opportunity is now open to everyone who feels that such courageous conduct ought to be rewarded in the best possible way.

We think it is best to speak with perfect frankness on this matter. The fund of about $600 subscribed up to the present is altogether too small an amount to represent two days of campaigning in this worthy cause. The news stories published in The Gazette have stated plainly the conditions of the Slater and Morren families and the public should have no difficulty in determining just how much is needed to make this movement a success. The three Slater children are all less than five years of age. The oldest one is supposed to start to school next fall. The two Morren children are already in school but they have many years to go before even their elementary education is complete. Unless the people of Kalamazoo give better monetary expression to their feelings of sympathy than has been evident thus far, the school careers of these five youngsters may be seriously endangered.

FRIDAY, MARCH 19, 1926.

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We trust that no one will be misled by the announcement, published yesterday, that "there is no immediate need of relief" for the Slater and Morren families. That simply means that the bereaved wives and children of the two firemen are not in perilous financial circumstances at the present moment. Their case, in other words, is not one for charity. And we may as well emphasize right now that the element of "charity" does not enter into the problem at all. The citizens who are sponsoring this movement are merely asking the people of Kalamazoo to make good on their obligation to Claus Slater and John Morren; to give assurance that the children of these heroic firemen will be given as good schooling as would have been theirs had their fathers not been forced to die in the service of the community.

The tragedy of last Saturday night was one of the worst shocks which has come to Kalamazoo in a long time. A wave of sincere, genuine human sympathy literally swept the entire city. Now there is a splendid chance to translate that sympathy into something tangible, something truly expressive of the way Kalamazoo feels toward men in its public service who do not hesitate to make the supreme sacifice when duty calls. The people cannot hope to compensate these children for the loss of their brave fathers. That is not the point. But the people can pay at least a part of their debt to Claus Slater and John Morren; they can, if they will, build up a fund to assure these children of the chance in life which men of such character as their fathers would have given them. That is fair enough, isn't it?

SUNDAY, MARCH 21, 1926.

FUTURE OF SIX FATHERLESS TOTS, WHOSE DADDIES GAVE LIVES TO CITY, DEPENDS ON RELIEF DRIVE

How Will Kalamazoo Reward Firemen's Supreme Devotion to Duty; Question Asked in Campaign.

In two modest Kalamazoo homes, one in Douglas avenue and the other in Lum avenue, a pall of sorrow has enveloped two bereaved mothers and six fatherless little tots—made fatherless because their daddies, John Morren and Claus Slater gave their lives fighting the First Methodist church fire a week ago.

Hearts of a sympathizing community have gone out to these grief-stricken families and the people of Kalamazoo and many surrounding cities have paid tribute to the memory of the two brave firemen who were crushed beneath falling roofs and walls. Funeral rites have been conducted for the firemen and the sorrowing families have returned to homes now husbandless and fatherless—to work out their salvation alone.

WILL KALAMAZOO AID?

But will Kalamazoo sit by and permit the widowed mothers to carry-on alone in the care and protection of their six fatherless children?

WILL KALAMAZOO AID?

But will Kalamazoo sit by and permit the widowed mothers to carry-on alone in the care and protection of their six fatherless children?

This is the question the Underwriters' club of Kalamazoo is asking residents of the community. It is a question which the club believes can be answered best by means of contributions to a fund which is now being raised for the care and education of the little children who are destined to pass through their most tender years without the kindly aid and guidance of a father.

ABOVE, left to right—Frances Morren, 7, Evelyn Morren, 9, Dorothy Morren, 3, and Mrs. Susanna Morren, the mother.
BELOW, left to right—Gordon Lyle Slater, 8 months, Donna Marie Slater, 4, Richard Leo Slater, 3, and Mrs. Cleo Slater, mother.

HOPES TO RAISE $6,000.

Touched by the tragedy of a week ago, the Underwriters' club took the first step to promote an organized movement for a relief fund for the bereaved families. By means of voluntary subscriptions the club hopes to obtain a fund of $6,000 at the least, "a thousand dollars a child," being the slogan adopted by the club.

More than $1,000 had been contributed to the fund Saturday night, it was announced by the committee promoting the campaign. This represents contributions received during four days. It represents the amount the club would like to put in trust for one child, and there are six little tots whose future welfare may now rest in the hands of the community.

Burdened by grief and weighted down by anxiety over obligations the brave little mothers are looking somewhat dubiously into the dim future, wondering what may be their fortune—good or bad? Their only concern now is whether or not they can provide for their little ones, three of whom are too young to realize the tragedy which has befallen them, their little sisters, and brother and mothers. Neither of the mothers is situated so that she might accept a position which would bring to the families even small remuneration. The demands of their brood make it necessary for them to remain in their homes, for there is one babe but eight months old in the Slater family and one but three years old in the Morren family. The oldest child is nine, while all the others are of the age requiring almost constant attention from the mothers.

MISSES HER DADDY.

The Morren children are Evelyn, nine years, Frances, seven years, and Dorothy, three years. Evelyn and Frances are old enough to realize the death of their father. Dorothy frolics about the Morren home unaware of the sorrow which has fallen upon her sisters and her mother. She laughs in her childish manner while the hearts of the others are sealed with sorrow. She looks with big, wide-open blue eyes into the tear-dimmed eyes of Evelyn and Frances and her mother. But she is not too young to miss her daddy, who was always a playmate with his children.

Donna Marie Slater, four years, and Richard Leo Slater, three years, know that their father is "missing" but are not yet old enough to realize the great tragedy which has taken him from them. Donna expressed her childish explanation of her father's disappearance in a pitiful manner when she told a newspaper representative the last of the week that "the church fell down on daddy."

EXPECTS DADDY TO RETURN.

"Daddy hasn't been home since," the little child sighed. At that moment an automobile driven by a fireman approached in front of the Slater home. Donna saw the uniformed man. "Oh, I wonder if that is Daddy," she cried, and started running to the curb. She stopped suddenly, recognizing that the fireman in the car was not her "daddy." Instead, it was Frank Linihan of the fire department, coming to the Slater home to offer aid from the firemen.

Two of the Morren children, Evelyn and Frances, go to school. Donna Marie and Richard Leo will start school within a year or two. The mothers of the children are determined that each child shall receive an education.

IN DEBT ON HOMES.

Financial benefits which the bereaved families will directly receive in the deaths of the husbands and fathers will be insufficient to provide for the future welfare of the children. These benefits will but only care for the immediate financial needs of the families. Benefits which will come under the Workingmen's compensation acts will not be paid in one lump sum but will spread over a period of 300 weeks, at a weekly allowance said to be $14 per family. In one family there will be a small insurance policy. But with all these benefits, there would not be sufficient funds to defray indebtedness on the two homes, aggregating $5,000, and care for the other needs.

Firemen of Kalamazoo the Metropolitan Club, and other agencies have come to the assistance of the families as far as immediate relief is concerned. The movement now being promoted throughout the city is for the purpose of creating a trust fund for the future needs, mainly the care and education of the children.

While the mothers are watching over their children in the two saddened homes, the Underwriters' club is continuing its campaign for funds. It is appealing to the community to contribute liberally to the fund and asks that all contribution liberally to the fund and asks that all contributions be given directly to the trust department of the First National bank. The movement will not be ended until the quota of $6,000 is reached.

SUNDAY, MARCH 21, 1926.

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FIRE ORIGIN UNKNOWN.

While statements of Arthur Stoops and John Triestram, the two boys who discovered the fire,

and those of firemen first on the the scene seem to indicate an overheated furnace was the cause of the conflagration, the Rev. Phelps reports that the blaze is considered of unknown origin. Claude S. Price, janitor of the church building, stated that there was very little fire in the furnace, according to his knowledge, Tuesday.

Stoops and Triestram, who had been playing in the boys' department of the Y. M. C. A. building, left there about 12:25 p. m., going through the alley between the "Y" and the church toward the rear of the latter and Academy street. Smoke could be seen coming from beneath a rear door, Stoops says, and a moment later an east basement window of the boiler room burst out. The boys peered in and saw the boiler enveloped in flames which were also leaping along the roof of the room. They immediately turned in an alarm and five lines of hose were in play within a short time.

DRAFTS FAN BLAZE.

Central station firemen and spectators alike believed the blaze to be almost under control when, simultaneously with the sight of new flames leaping from the roof, crackling of fire could be heard at the west side of the church. Dense smoke soon covered the downtown district and opened doors and burned out sections of the roof fanned drafts through the building which turned it into a roaring furnace.

Swelling crowds were kept back by fire lines as sturdy Kalamazoo firemen from Companies 1, 2, 4, 5, and 6, fought two hours to bring the blazes under control and protect the Y. M. C. A., First Baptist church, and First Reformed church, which, with the First Congregational edifice, covered the entire block bounded by Main, Church, Park, and Academy streets. Part of the south wall, a section of the west roof, and a larger part of the east wall and roof crashed to earth, and, though the tower remained intact, it was a brave and untiring crew of firemen who fought in armours of ice and frost to the end. Many of the men had to be released from jackets to remove their rubber coats after the fire.

PLANNED ENLARGEMENTS

Tuesday's disastrous fire upset extensive plans of the board of trustees to enlarge and repair the church, it is said. The board had several weeks before voted to spend a considerable sum to add another floor over the north and west wings of the church.

A meeting between the board and representatives of the firm of Billingham and Cobb, architects and engineers, had been set for 2:30 p. m. Tuesday. Draftsmen had been working on the plans and blue prints for the addition for two weeks. They had just been completed and were ready for final submission to the board of trustees when the church burst into flames.

FEARS WALLS MAY CRUMBLE.

City Building Inspector Andrew Leak, Tuesday afternoon warned the police to keep the building roped off to protect pedestrians passing along Academy and Park streets. The inspector fears the walls will crumble as the ice, now encasing the walls, thaws.

Dudley Luce of Lansing, deputy state fire marshall, in Kalamazoo Tuesday, witnessed the conflagration. He characterized the blaze as one of the most stubborn he had witnessed in several years.

"A few minutes after the fire got under way, it was apparent the church could not be saved," he said. "The flames had too much of a start. Members of the Kalamazoo fire department should be complimented on their successful efforts to keep the flames confined to the one structure. The firemen are certainly smoke eaters. I did not see one of them driven back by the dense barage that rolled from the building during the height of the fire."

WARNING FOR JANITORS.

"I hope that Tuesday's fire at the Congregational church will serve as a warning to all janitors not to build too hot a fire and then go away and leave it," Fire Chief Charles Russell announced Wednesday. "Tuesday's blaze was the second church fire within the last month, and it is my belief that both started from the same cause

"From all reports Kalamazoo's firemen did remarkably well in keeping the fire from spreading to other buildings. The church burned like a straw stack."

Chief Russell was unable to lead his men in Tuesday's fire, being confined to his bed with neuritis, contracted several nights ago during the fire at the Roamer Motor Car Company coal sheds. He has been off duty for the last four days and is still too ill to answer alarms.

Two children, one a girl four years old, and a boy about five, were knocked down and drenched when one of the fire hose broke away during the blaze. They were carried into the Y. M. C. A. building and were later taken to their homes. Neither was seriously injured.

WEDNESDAY, DECEMBER 30, 1925.

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THURSDAY, JULY 8, 1926.

ANOTHER CHURCH FIRE.

In the complete destruction by fire of the First Presbyterian Church edifice at Rose and South streets, Kalamazoo loses another one of its most familiar landmarks. The large building destroyed Tuesday night was erected 42 years ago to replace the structure which had met a similar fate in 1883. While the passing of this venerable house of worship cannot but be attended by a rather general feeling of regret throughout the city, there is some consolation in the knowledge that it probably would not have remained standing much longer anyway. The first unit of the new home of the First Presbyterian Church Society, on South street one block west of the old site, is rapidly nearing completion, and when finished it will be one of the most attractive works of architecture in Kalamazoo. It is unfortunate that the members of the Presbyterian congregation will be forced to undergo the inconvenience of holding their services in emergency quarters until their new edifice is ready for occupancy.

The First Presbyterian Church is the third large church building in Kalamazoo to have been demolished by flames within the last few months. The people of this city will long remember the First Methodist Episcopal Church disaster, in which two of our courageous fire fighters lost their lives. Some time before that the Congregational Church was burned beyond repair. Fire started twice in the Presbyterian building prior to Tuesday night, but was successfully combatted before any serious damage had been done. Lodge halls also appear to have been favorite victims of the epidemic of destructive blazes which has been sweeping this city. The rooms of the Knights of Columbus were utterly ruined by the conflagration which all but destroyed the Chase block; the Moose Temple on Portage street suffered a heavy loss from the flames, and fires of less serious proportions have invaded the Knights of Pythias building twice and the Odd Fellows Hall on Main street.

Naturally, the fact that churches and lodges have been the chief sufferers from this series of blazes has given rise to a great deal of discussion and speculation on the part of Kalamazoo's citizenry. With few exceptions, the origins of these fires have been very much in doubt. Surely the loss of the First Presbyterian Church on Tuesday evening could not have been due to the operation of a defective heating plant. In nearly all cases the fires have started while the buildings or halls were unoccupied, and at hours of the day when they quite naturally would be unoccupied. No one has any desire to encourage unwarranted alarm or lend strength to what may be mere suspicion, but Kalamazoo has had far more than its share of serious fires during the last several months and most o them have been characterized by an element of mystery which cannot longer be ignored.

Of course, it is impossible to point to any definite evidence to the effect that a firebug has been operating in Kalamazoo. But it is equally impossible to show any other substantial cause for the repeated attacks by fire on lodge halls and church buildings. Because of their structure and the fact that they are unoccupied the greater part of the time, churches make easy "material" for the demented incendiary. If he can gain entrance he can go about his destructive business unobserved, and flames once started in such a building make rapid headway. The lodge halls which have burned in Kalamazoo recently have all been situated in closely built downtown sections, and if the fires had not been checked as efficiently as they were the resulting spectacles would have been such as to delight the eyes of a confirmed pyromaniac. The three investigations which have been started by local and state authorities are quite in order.

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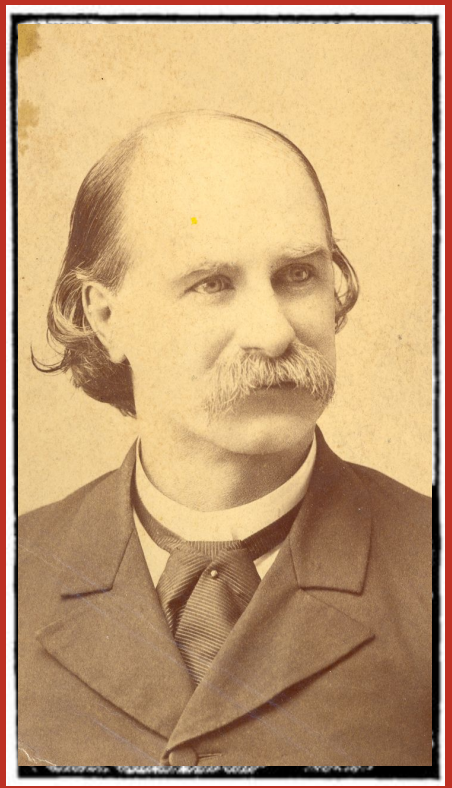
CHURCH CORNERSTONE YIELDS OLD BOX OF HISTORICAL DATA

Second Congregational church, erected in 1832, and (below), the Rev. W. A. Waterman, pastor at the time the structure recently burned was built.



SUNDAY, MARCH 7, 1926.

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Workmen employed in razing the First Congregational church, destroyed by fire last December, have removed its cornerstone containing interesting records and information concerning the erection of church and events which were taking place in Kalamazoo July 3, 1889, when the cornerstone was layed. The strong box containing these records was discovered by accident when a workman's pick broke through the walls of the receptacle.

Photographs of the Rev. W. A. Waterman, then pastor of the church, the second Congregational church built in Kalamazoo, and interesting views of the Kalamazoo during its early days were found in the cornerstone. Newspapers of the day and others dating back as far as 1892 were also in the box.

A small Bible was also found among the old papers. It was presented by Deacon D. A. McNair in August of 1852. The church destroyed by fire was the third edifice built by the Congregationalists of Kalamazoo.

There were two hymn books, one presented by Roberts and Hillhouse, drugs and books, 123 West Main street. There were a large number of church periodicals, letters of congratulation from ministers of other cities, a list of the church members who subscribed to the church's building fund and a mass of other interesting data.

FORMED JUNE 6, 1835

A historical sketch of the church disclosed that it was formed of 14 members June 6, 1835. It was then purely Presbyterian, and continued as such until January, 1841, when it adopted a rotary session. In January 1842, it adopted the Congregational form of church government. It remained connected with the Kalamazoo Presbytery until June, 1848, when it united with other churches in forming the Kalamazoo Congregational Association.

The Rev. S. Woodbury was pastor from its formation until August, 1839. The pulpit was vacant until 1840 when the Rev. O. P. Hoyt was installed. Other ministers who served as pastor were the Rev. A. S. Kedzie, John T. Avery, Granville Wardell, Edward Taylor, Henry Mills, F. F. Ford, Oliver S. Dean, Frank Russell, W. H. Thomas, Charles O. Brown, William A. Waterman, Casper Wistar Hiatt, Thomas E. Barr, R. W. McLaughlin.

In 1836 a church house 26 feet by 40 feet was constructed of wood. Fifteen more feet were added in 1841. In 1852 a church was built of brick 44 feet by 70 feet. A steady growth of the congregation made it necessary to enlarge this church several times, the history shows.

At a special meeting held April 25, 1887, it was determined to build a third church, the one which was destroyed by fire last December. The cornerstone was laid with appropriate exercises, July 3, 1889, and the church was dedicated June 22, 1890.

Some of the contributors to the church building fund, "raised for the purpose of erecting, finishing, and furnishing a suitably commodious house of worship for the First Congregational church of Kalamazoo were: Mr. and Mrs. O. M. Allen, $5,100; S. A. Brown, $700; Julius C. Burroughs and wife, $400; Henry Beckwith, $200; C. H. Bird, $200; L. Cahill, $6,500; E. A. Crane and wife, $100; G. W. Crooks, $100; Mrs. L. B. Clement, $100; S. A. Gibson, $1,500; Gilmore Brothers, $250; L. M. Gates, $400; L. Hull, $3,000; T. Hudson, $600; Dr. H. O. Hitchcock, $400. D. H. Haines, $100; Pennel Hobbs, $100; W. E. Hill, $200; Mrs. E. A. House, $500; Mrs. T. M. Hollingsworth, $100; Mrs. T. Hudson, $100; Andrew Krom, $1,500; Ladies' Church Society, $1,000; D. B. Merrill, $1,400; May Rockwell, $250; W. H. McCourtie, $500; Mrs. W. H. McCourtie, $400. Thomas McCullough, $100; J. W. Osborne, $650; Dr. H. B. Osborne $300; L. C. Pratt, $200; P. Ranney, $1,000; George A. Smith, $100; John G. Ter Haar, $125; Guy DeKnecke, $125; Philo Bradenburg, $125; R. J. Williamson, $100; John E. Woodward, $100; H. F. Weimer, $200; C. G. Weed, $100; the Rev. W. A. Waterman for children, $125; Y. P. C. E. Society, $300.

ECHO OF OLD SCHOOL

A program of commencement exercises of Mrs. Sheldon's school for ladies was included in the cornerstone treasures. The exercises were held Thursday, June 27, 1889, and the graduation class included Mary Lyon Fawcett, Juliet May Sebring, and Grace Florence Sweetland. The program includes songs by Annie H. Burnham, Carrie Burdick and Blanche Carse. The address was by the Hon Horatio Q. Butterfield.

The girls' chorus included Vida H. Smith, Laura L. Burdick, Kate E. Selkirk, Kittie C. Waterbury, Ida Bell Smith, Eva McLin, Pauline Avery, and Edith M. Osborn.

Some of the old papers placed in the cornerstone included church periodicals and missionary magazines dating back as far as 1850. There was a "Michigan Telegraph" of June 23, 1852, Kalamazoo Gazette of Aug. 1, 1852, "De Nederlander" of Aug. 6, 1852, which was Kalamazoo's Holland-American newspaper edited by G. Van De Wall.

The cornerstone of the little brick church built in 1852 was layed Sept. 15, according to another brief mesasge found in the strong box.

The letter read: "There are in this village at this date six Protestant churches and a small Irish Roman Catholic church. They include the Calvinistic Baptist church with 176 members; Methodist Episcopal church with 80 members; St. Lukes church with 50 members; Dutch Reform-

SUNDAY, MARCH 7, 1926.

1 of 2

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ed church with 60 members; Presbyterian church will 180 members and the Congregational church with 160 members.

"There are four common schools which are intended to be consolidated into one Union school. There is also one and sometimes two private schools, also a female seminary and a Baptist Literary and Theological seminary, each in early stages of its growth, but promising.

"How changed will be the conditions of this place (now unmbering between 3,000 and 4,000 inhabitants), of its church when this shall be brought forth for perusual of some distant generation. May he then look down from the heights of heaven and see freedom and Christianity over spreading the earth."

This message was signed by A. S. Kedzie.

In another note A. S. Kedzie wrote in 1851, "It may not be amiss to preserve in this box a notice of the Ladies' Library Association. This body was formed in the winter of 1851. It is composed of ladies of all the different religious societies in this place. Each pays 25 cents a year for the use of the library. Gentlemen are entitled to the same privileges for one dollar a year.

"A library of about 150 very choice works have been obtained. No book is admitted unless approved by a library committee chosen from each church. A lecture is delivered before the association once each month. The ladies and gentlemen of the association spend one evening each month together for a literary chat.

CORNERSTONE SERMON

During the laying of the cornerstone, the Rev. Waterman said:

"The new edifice to be built upon this cornerstone has been made a necessity. A church structure has always been the object and desire of devoted hearts. It has become indispensible to the existence, stability, and efficiency of the body of believers. It is the real abiding place of the Holy Spirit.

"We shall soon be beyond the need of temples, but they who remain will find the need remaining. We must leave the tools and workshop in good order for the generations which are to follow us.

"This material structure will some day crumble to dust but the truth of the Gospel will have been transmitted into the immortal force, in the minds of men, and in the progress of all good. This edifice will be our testimonial to a living faith."

An accompanying bit of history placed in the cornerstone of 1889 showed that at that time there were 18 churches in Kalamazoo, one college, a female seminary, and a private boarding school. The population was about 22,000.

"The chief products are carts, carriages, and celery," the note stated. "The Hon. Otto Ihling is the mayor of the city. The Hon. Cyrus Luce is governor of Michigan. The Hon. Benjamin Harrison is president of the United States.

"The laying of the cornerstone was attended by a large gathering of the congregation and citizens. This new structure will no doubt be one of the most convenient, commodious and elegant edifices in the state and the citizens today should feel justly proud of their heroic undertaking. The exercises were characterized by simplicity with which our Pilgrim Fathers inaugurated the religious history of our country. All pastors of the city attended the ceremonies and gave short addresses."

All papers and records removed from the cornerstone have been turned over to the Rev. Torrance T. Phelps, pastor of the church. They will be placed in the archieves of the new church when its cornerstone is laid, it is planned.

SUNDAY, MARCH 14, 1926.

DISCUSS ORIGIN OF FIRE.

Opinion is divided regarding the origin of the fire. Due to the fact that four different churches have caught fire within the last five months—two of them having been completely ruined, and also because several other disastrous downtown blazes have occurred during the last two months, opinions were voiced that the fire may have been of incendiary origin. Others were of the belief an overheated furnace or flue caused the fire, while their were still others who thought defective wiring may have started it. Harry Oswald, city electrical inspector, stated that the system of wiring in the church was of old type, but added the extensions which had been made to electrical apparatus in the church had been of late design.

The First Methodist church was the first to claim human lives since the disastrous Hall Brothers conflagration in 1907, when 10 firemen were killed. The fatalities at the church fire occurred after the fire had been subdued and the only task left to the firemen was the wetting down of the burning ruins inside the four walls.

The janitor of the church could not be located Saturday night, but it is believed he had attended the furnace fire late Saturday afternoon, to have the church warm for the Sunday services. Neither was it possible to ascertain the exact amount of insurance carried on the structure, although it was stated by certain members of the church that the insurance would total $50,000.

RED HOT FLUE RAZED CHURCH, PROBERS FIND

Overheated Furnace Blamed for Destruction of Methodist Edifice.

That the First Methodist church fire March 13 started from an overheated furnace and flue, was the report of an official investigating committee composed of Fire Chief Charles H. Russell, Sheriff Jerome S. Borden, Acting Police Chief Roy W. Carney, and Frank Flaitz, contractor, Tuesday.

A thorough investigation of the ruins at the church site was conducted by this committee in a determined effort to learn the origin of the fire which claimed the lives of two firemen and wrought property damage estimated above $100,000.

MAKE THOROUGH PROBE.

Each of the four furnaces in the church basement, all of the flue lines, and all electrical wiring that could be traced, were examined by the committee and at the conclusion of the inspection there remained but one plausible theory as to the origin of the fire. Evidence found in and around the furnace which stood in the basement directly beneath the church organ, led the committee to believe the heating unit had become dangrously hot, setting fire to the floor joists.

The flue to the furnace in question is at present a rosy red color, indicating that it had been red hot. Other flues are still shiny and show no evidence of having been overheated. The joists and floor above the furnace are charcoal, while the joists in other parts of the first floor are only smoke and soot-stained.

SET FIRE TO JOISTS.

The investigating committee is certain the fire started in the floor joists above the furnace near the rar of th basement, eating through the floor and coursing up a partition to the hoof. Wooden shingles, said to have been beneath the newer roof covering, furnished fuel to the rapidly spreading flames.

Sheriff Borden, who announced the committee's report, stated that all four of the furnaces had been well filld with coal and had evidently been "banked" with coal. Electrical wiring units in the building, as many as could be inspected, were found in such a condition as not to produce fire.

WEDNESDAY, MARCH 24, 1926.

WEDNESDAY, JULY 7, 1926.

Flames Breaking Out at 11:20 p. m. Completely Destroy Structure at Rose and South Streets.

SET BY FIREBUG, BELIEF

Officials Promise Drastic Action to Apprehend Incendiary After Long Series of Fires.

Believing that the 12 church and lodge hall fires in Kalamazoo since December, 1925, may have been in part, at least, of incendiary origin, a city and state investigation which may lead to the apprehension of a firebug, was begun early Wednesday morning by Police Chief Roy W. Carney, Deputy State Fire Marshall Frank Burmaster, and Sheriff Jerome S. Borden.

Deputy Warden Burmaster announced shortly before noon that two officials from the state fire marshal's office at Lansing would arrive in Kalamazoo during the day to join with the local officers in investigating, not only the First Presbyterian church fire Tuesday night, but also the other major church and lodge hall blazes.

BELIEVE FIREBUG DID IT

The police and sheriff's departments and the deputy fire marshal will conduct separate investigations, but will co-operate in all the work.

Opinion that the series of disastrous fires—at least those involving churches and lodge hall, were incendiary were emphatically expressed following the Presbyterian church fire and the officials themselves are strongly of the opinion that a firebug is at work in Kalamazoo.

In each of the previous big fires the police, sheriff and state fire marshal officials conducted investigations, but found no evidence which would point conclusively to incendiarism.

INDICATE ARSON, BELIEF.

"The fact there have been so many big fires, under conditions more or less mysterious, and occuring quite generally at regular intervals, indicates that at least some of the blazes have been set," declared Chief of Police Carney. "If a firebug is at work, it may be a difficult matter to apprehend him, unless he should be discovered in the act of setting another fire. Virtually all the evidence of incendiarism is destroyed with the burning of the buildings."

Sheriff Borden and Deputy Marshal Burmaster agreed with the chief that the series of fires would arouse suspicion that a firebux was at work in Kalamazoo. "We will leave no stone unmoved in our investigation of the fire," declared Sheriff Borden.

TOTAL LOSS $700,000

With the destruction of the First Presbyterian church building Tuesday night, Kalamazoo's fire loss for the last seven months reached approximately $700,000. All of this loss has been incurred in 15 fires. Some of the buildings which were later destroyed were afire as many as three different times.

Officers called attention to that fact that every one of the major fires has occurred either between 5:00 in the afternoon and 12:00 midnight, at noontime, early in the morning before working hours, or during the forenoon of holidays.

Two of the disastrous fires—the First Methodist church and the Trades and Labor Council hall, occurred about 5:00 Saturday afternoon.

SOME OCCUR ON SUNDAYS

Three of the fires—the East Avenue M. E. church, the Hershfield store and the Boudeman block, occurred Sunday forenoons.

The First Congregational church and the Moose temple fires occurred around the noon hour.

The Chase block fire was the only early-morning blaze.

The Phythian building fires were all in the late afternoon.

All the fires which were discovered in the First Presbyterian church occurred in the late evening, usually around 11:00.

The peculiar circumstances of these fires are about the only facts on which the officers have to conduct their investigation. A rigid inspection of the charred ruins of the Presbyterian church was being made Wednesday

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PRESBYTERIAN CHURCH FIRE LOSS $100,000

Third Downtown Religious Structure to Be Razed; Aggregate Damage $700,000.

BARE WALLS STANDING

Two Firemen Overcome by Smoke After Collapse of Roof.

Fire, believed to have been of incendiary origin, destroyed the First Presbyterian church building at South and Rose streets at 11:30 Tuesday night, with a loss estimated at $100,000 to $125,000.

Two firemen were partially overcome by smoke and gas fumes and seven others narrowly escaped injury or death when a portion of the roof fell to the street. The fire endangered a score or more downtown blocks.

TWO PREVIOUS FIRES

It was the third fire which had broken out in that structure within the last four months. The first fire, late in the winter, had started near a moving picture booth. The second blaze, which occurred during the Knights Templar conclave here in June, was discovered at 11:00 in the evening near the front end of the building. That fire did considerable damage to the front lobby, but was extinguished before it spread.

The Presbyterian church fire Tuesday night was the third big church blaze to occur in Kalamazoo this year. The First Congregational church, just one block from the ill-fated Presbyterian building, was the first large church to be completely destroyed. The First Methodist church fire, March 13, was the second major blaze and the one which claimed the lives of two firemen.

In addition to these three major church fires in which the destruction has been virtually complete, there have been smaller blazes discovered in places of worship and which were extinguished. The East Avenue M. E. church fire was badly gutted in December, 1925, while the Church of Christ was visited by a small fire.

15 FIRES SINCE DEC. 16.

The Presbyterian fire constituted the fifteenth big fire in Kalamazoo since Dec. 16, 1925. Of these 16 fires, 12 of them were in churches or in buildings in which fraternal organizations held meetings.

The complete list of the major fires, which resulted in an aggregate loss of approximately $700,000, follows:

CHURCHES

East Avenue Methodist church (Dec. 17, the first of the series of church fires), $10,000.
First Congregational church (complete loss), $175,000.
First Presbyterian church (moving picture booth fire) $50.
First Methodist church (complete loss), $100,000.
First Presbyterian church (lobby fire, $250.
First Presbyterian church (complete loss), $125,000.

LODGE HALLS

Knights of Pythias temple (first fire in basement, small loss), $150.
Knights of Pythias temple (second fire heavy loss), $10,000.
Chase block fire (Knights of Columbus quarters), $100,000.
Moose temple (housing nine different lodges), $100,000.
Trades and Labor Council hall, $10,000.
Hershfield store (housing four lodges), $8,000.

OTHERS

Boudeman block, $10,000.
Sutherland Paper company (paraffin plant), $25,000.
Marcy's garage, $20,000.

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BUILDINGS ENDANGERED.

Among the buildings which were endangered by the Presbyterian church fire were:

The Pythian building, 10 feet east of the church.

Y. W. C. A. building, 30 feet north of the church.

Public Library, directly across the street.

Park club, on the southwest corner of South and Rose streets.

Odd Fellows temple, directly west of the Park club.

City hall, just west of the Odd Fellows' temple.

Postoffice, at Burdick and South streets.

Boudeman block, just east of the Pythian building.

A close watch was kept at all these buildings to warn the firemen if any partion of the roofs should be ignited by firebrands. Police and sheriff's officers established "beats" to and from these buildings. None of the surrounding structures were ignited, however.

Danger warnings were posted on the church building Wednesday morning by Building Inspector Andrew C. Leak, following an inspection of the ruins. The walls which are left standing are considered dangerous as are also the ruins which are piled high on the inside.

The fire, occurring at the time it did, held up street car traffic all over the city. Cars bound for their last run of the night were brought to a standstill when the power on all the lines was shut off and when long lines of hose were drawn across the tracks.

Every firemen and every piece of fire-fighting equipment was pressed into service with the outbreak of the fire. All reserve firemen were called on duty and remained at their posts during the entire night. So dangerous did the fire become that the reserve truck, which is usually kept at Central station for emergency calls during a big fire, was rushed to the scene and kept in action.

Pumpers were located on every corner surrounding the church block and these powerful machines shot streams of water into the various hose lines at the rate of from 1,400 to 1,800 gallons per minute. Ten hose lines, eight shooting water directly into the building and two being manned from the Y. W. C. A. and Pythian building, were kept in operation continuously during the fire.

With the sounding of the general alarm, the Salvation Army, the stewards at the Odd Fellows' temple, and Mrs. Jerome S. Borden, matron at the County jail, prepared coffee, doughnuts, and sandwiches for the firemen.

FRIDAY, JULY 9, 1926.

PRESBYTERIANS WILL MEET AT H. S. AUDITORIUM

Officials Continue Probe of Fire Which Destroyed Edifice.

First Presbyterian church services for the next year, at least, will be held in the Central high school auditorium, it was announced Friday, following a conference of church trustees with the board of education.

The Sunday services, July 11, will be held at 11:00 in the forenoon, in the auditorium. The union services in the evening will be conducted at the First Baptist church.

MEET WITH BOARD.

A committee composed of Dr. J. T. Upjohn and George Irwin conferred with the board of education on behalf of the church trustees and made arrangements for use of the church. The Presbyterian board believes it will be fully a year before a new church will be near completion.

Sunday school at the Presbyterian church has been discontinued for the summer and there are no meetings now of the young peoples' society.

The board of trustees met Thursday afternoon with officials of a firm of architects in Chicago for the purpose of going over the plans for the new church building and completing arrangements for starting of the new structure. The plans soon will be completed, it was announced.

PROBE CONTINUES.

No new developments in the two investigations being conducted into the Presbyterian church fire, were reported Friday by the sheriff's and police departments nor by Deputy State Fire Marshal Frank Burmaster, who is working with two men from the state fire marshal's office.

The investigation is to continue, however, and will cover not only the Presbyterian church fire but also the several other church and lodge hall fires which have occurred in Kalamazoo during the last six months.

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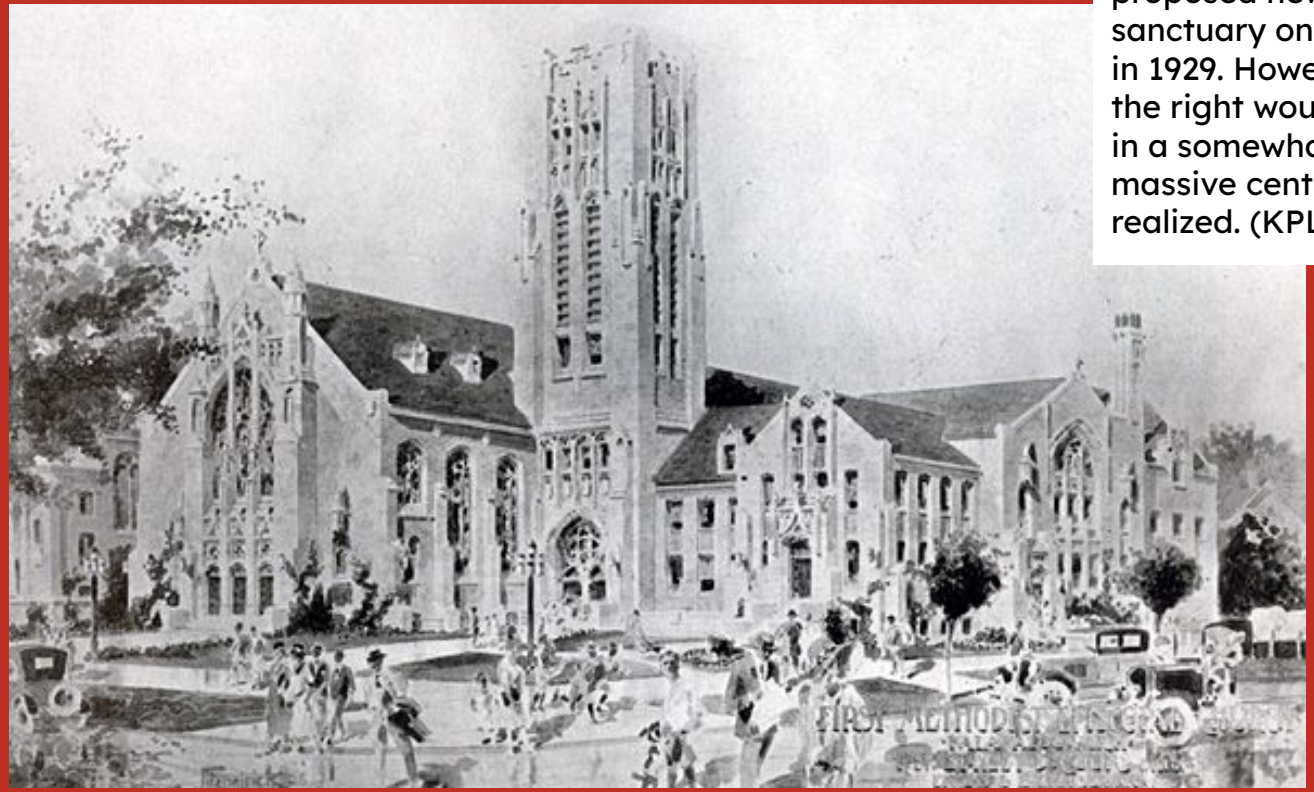
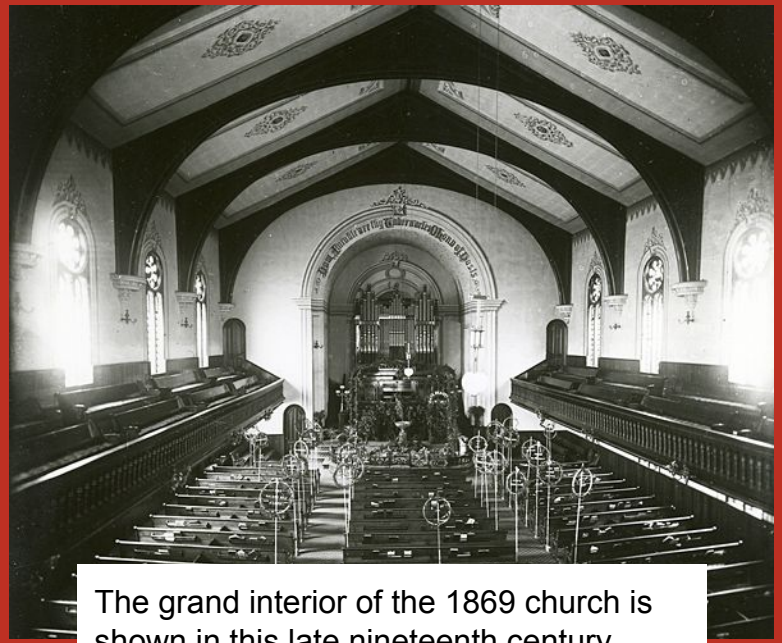


Ernest S. Batterson's rendering of the proposed new church building. The sanctuary on the left was completed in 1929. However, the church house on the right would not be built until 1950, in a somewhat simplified form. The massive central tower has never been realized. (KPL)

The third First Methodist building has overlooked Bronson Park since its completion in 1929. Photograph take by David Kohrman, Kalamazoo Public Library staff, March 2013.



The grand interior of the 1869 church is shown in this late nineteenth century photograph. The painted stencil designs on the walls and ceiling were typical for the era. (KPL)

FIRST PRESBYTERIAN CHURCH, KALAMAZOO, MICH.—34

WEDNESDAY, DECEMBER 30, 1925.

BURNED CHURCH TO BE REBUILT BY FALL OF '26

Preliminary Plans Call for Starting of Construction in Spring.

WALLS TO BE TORN DOWN

Services to Continue in People's Church; Flames Stop Plans for Enlarging Old Edifice.

On the site where this morning drab, skelton-like walls stood as sentinels guarding the ruins of the First Congregational church, destroyed by Tuesday afternoon's $175,000 ,re, a completely new and modern structure will rise. The congregation, undaunted by the colossal loss, will continue regular services in the People's church until the fall of 1926, when, it is expected, the new edifice will be ready for occupancy.

While weary and frozen firemen fought to save nearby buildings and to extinguish the smoldering wreckage of what had been Kalamazoo's largest Protestant church Tuesday afternoon, a joint meeting of the First Congregational church boards accepted the challenge of fate with a spirit of optimism. The board of trustees and the advisory board members convened together and accepted an invitation to continue, wihout a break, regular services in the People's church. Immediate steps to build a new structure, complete and modern in every way, were taken.

PLANNING NEW CHURCH.

The joint board meeting members decided to appoint a building committee to formulate plans for a new First Congregational church and arrange to submit preliminary sketches for adoption by the congregation at an early date. Robert E. Staebler was named chairman of the committee consisting of L. W. Sutherland, Frank D. Fuller, Guy Wilson, W. O. Jones, A. B. MacDonald and Donald S. Gilmore, who will work with the Rev. Torrance T. Phelps, pastor, in drawing up preliminary plans.

"Our church rises with optimism and energy to meet the urgent challenge," the Rev. Phelps pastor, declares. The walls of the old building, built in 1890, will be torn down and, if initial plans are carried out work will start in early spring so that the new and more modern house of worship will be available by next fall.

FRIDAY, APRIL 2, 1926.

START WORK ON $250,000 CHURCH BY MAY 15, PLAN

Action of Congregational Board Unanimous, Announcement.

GOING UP ON OLD SITE

Will Contain Stage, Church House, Nave to Seat 800 Persons, and Walled Garden.

The erection of one of the finest church structures in Western Michigan was assured Thursday afternoon when the trustees of the First Congregational church of this city voted unanimously to enter into contract with Amar Embury II, New York architect, for the plans and specifications for such a building. According to Robert E. Staebler, chairman of the building committee, Mr. Embury is to have complete specifications ready within three weeks. Following their receipt bids will be asked. It is hoped to begin actual construction work not later than May 15.

The trustees met at 4:00 Thursday afternoon in the People's church parlors. Martin H. DeLoof, chairman of the board, presided. The building committee had been in session with Embury on Monday. At that time they considered several plans. Their final selection met with favor on the part of the trustees. While no estimates have been attempted as to the costs of the new church home, it is the general opinion that the structure will represent an outlay of from $225,000 to $250,000. This amount does not include site, organ, furnishings, or equipment.

PLANS WALLED GARDEN.

The new First Congregational church will be erected at Academy and South Park streets, on the site occupied for the last 75 years by churches of this denomination. It will replace the structure totally destroyed by fire. The plan accepted calls for a building Renaissance gothic in type and provides not only for a church proper, but in addition a well arranged church house, its general layout, the church proper facing Academy street and extends north and south, while the church house connects in the rear and extends east and west the width of the property. The site is not only sufficient to accommodate these two structures, but will at the same time permit of a walled garden, 64x88 feet in dimensions, being located on the plat immediately at Academy and Park streets. This attractive green and floral setting will add immeasurably to the general effectiveness of the whole.

PUBLIC SALE

The following items salvaged from the fire of the First Congregational Church:

Lawn Mowers.	Large Bell.
Steam Radiators.	Steam Pipe.
35 Common chairs.	Large Arm Chairs.
15 Tables.	25 Oak Doors.
Large Kitchen range.	Pedestal Stand.
Floor Matting.	2 Pulpit Chairs.
Oak Benches.	Storm Sash.
Book Case.	Small Desk.

This material will be offered for sale at 2.00 P. M., Thursday, April 8th, at 216 E. Kalamazoo Ave. Further particulars may be obtained from

GEORGE POWELL,
M. H. DE LOOF.

TUESDAY, APRIL 6, 1926.

FRIDAY, APRIL 2, 1926.

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH TO BE BEAUTIFUL EDIFICE

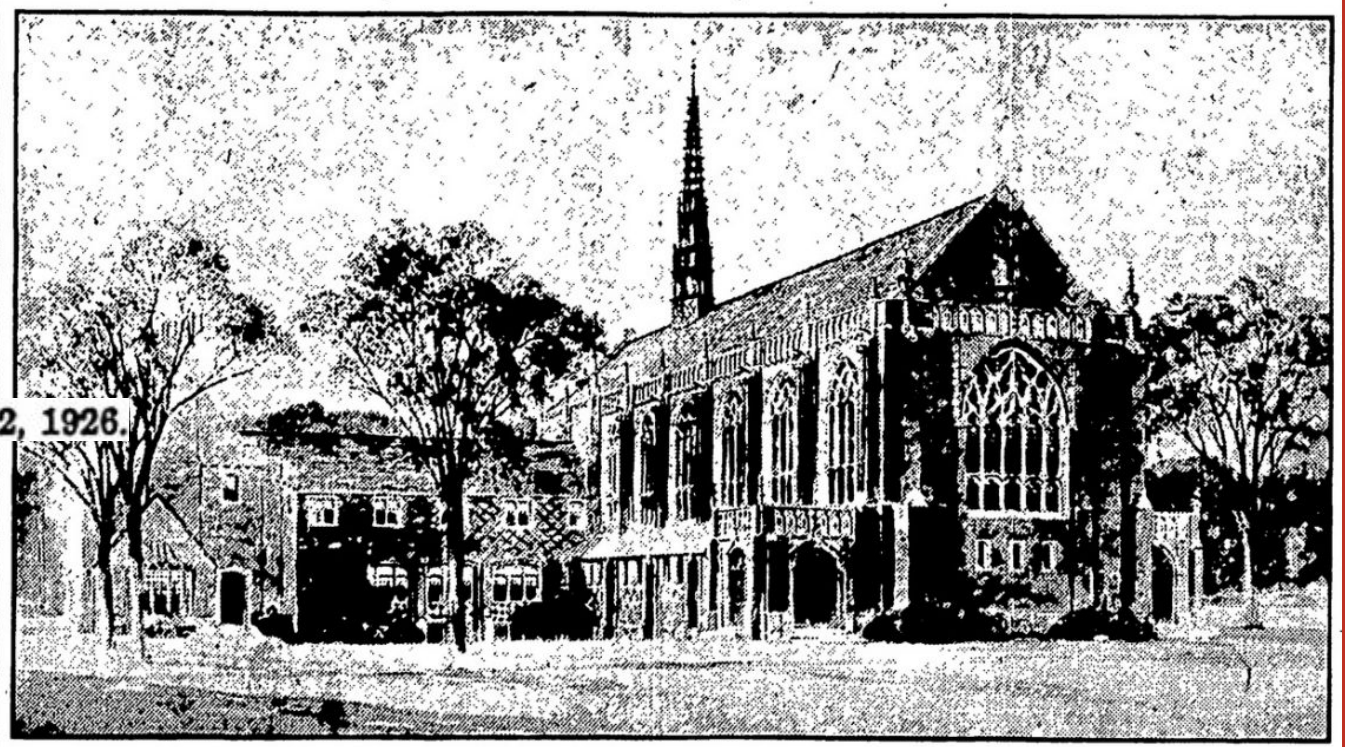
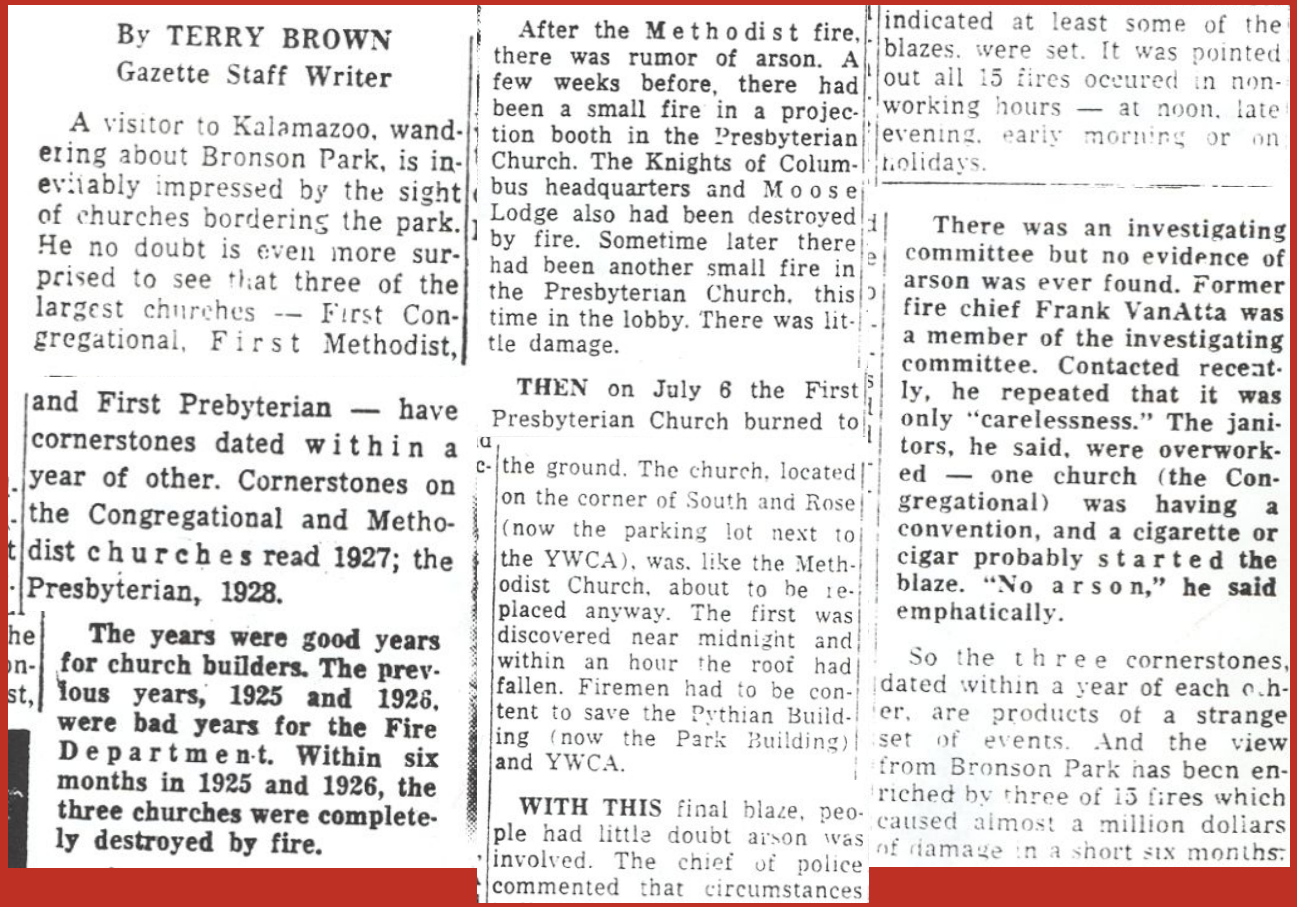


Photo of Drawing by Slocum Bros.

Work on the new First Congregational church, of renaissance gothic design, with church-house and walled garden, will be started not later than May 15, it was announced today by the board. The structure will be one of the finest in Western Michigan. A view of the nave with vaulted ceiling may be found on Page 34.

“1940s Building Outside”

“1928 Building Sunken Garden”



By TERRY BROWN
Gazette Staff Writer

A visitor to Kalamazoo, wandering about Bronson Park, is inevitably impressed by the sight of churches bordering the park. He no doubt is even more surprised to see that three of the largest churches — First Congregational, First Methodist, and First Prebyterian — have cornerstones dated within a year of other. Cornerstones on the Congregational and Methodist churches read 1927; the Presbyterian, 1928.

The years were good years for church builders. The previous years, 1925 and 1926, were bad years for the Fire Department. Within six months in 1925 and 1926, the three churches were completely destroyed by fire.

After the Methodist fire, there was rumor of arson. A few weeks before, there had been a small fire in a projection booth in the Presbyterian Church. The Knights of Columbus headquarters and Moose Lodge also had been destroyed by fire. Sometime later there had been another small fire in the Presbyterian Church, this time in the lobby. There was little damage.

THEN on July 6 the First Presbyterian Church burned to the ground. The church, located on the corner of South and Rose (now the parking lot next to the YWCA), was, like the Methodist Church, about to be replaced anyway. The first was discovered near midnight and within an hour the roof had fallen. Firemen had to be content to save the Pythian Building (now the Park Building) and YWCA.

WITH THIS final blaze, people had little doubt arson was involved. The chief of police commented that circumstances indicated at least some of the blazes were set. It was pointed out all 15 fires occured in non-working hours — at noon, late evening, early morning or on holidays.

There was an investigating committee but no evidence of arson was ever found. Former fire chief Frank VanAtta was a member of the investigating committee. Contacted recently, he repeated that it was only "carelessness." The janitors, he said, were overworked — one church (the Congregational) was having a convention, and a cigarette or cigar probably started the blaze. "No arson," he said emphatically.

So the three cornerstones, dated within a year of each other, are products of a strange set of events. And the view from Bronson Park has been enriched by three of 15 fires which caused almost a million dollars of damage in a short six months.

2 KALAMAZOO GAZETTE, SATURDAY, JUNE 29, 1963.

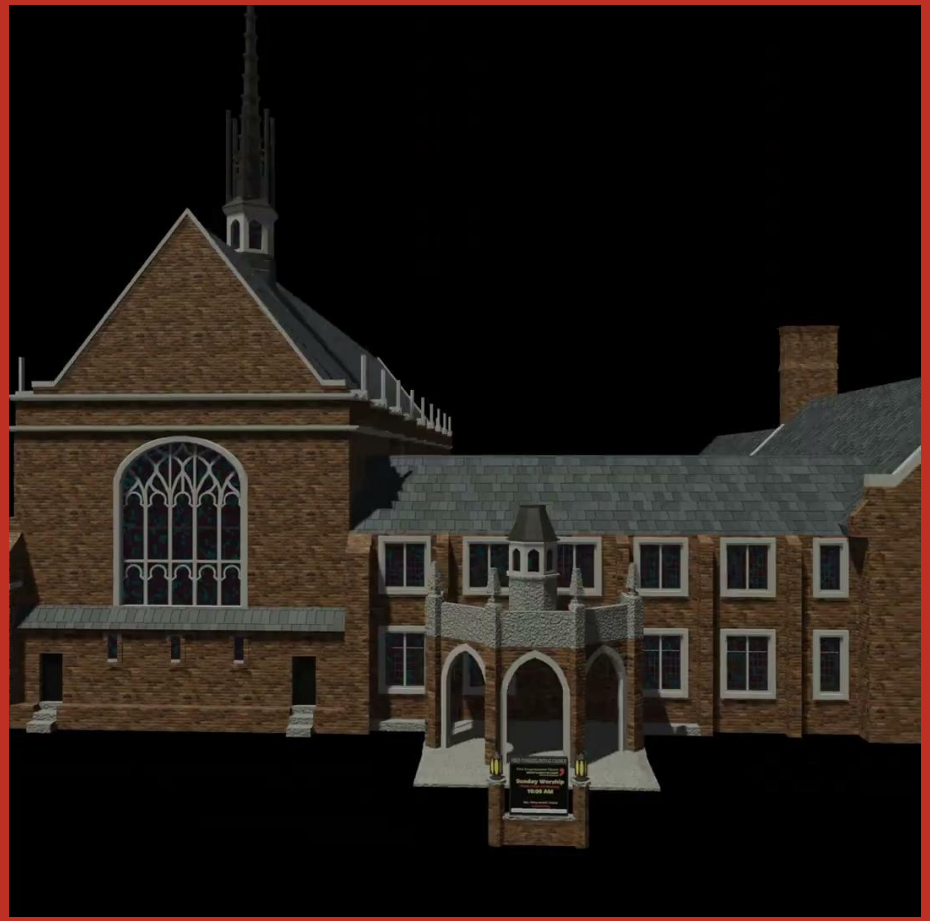
The Cornerstone Story

Downtown Churches Rebuilt Following 1925-26 Fires

SATURDAY, JUNE 29, 1963.

summary timeline deaths investigations rebuilding

FCC



Video: Me
Models: Me
Music: Me
Script: Me/ChatGPT4
Voice: OpenAI Ember

Academy Street 1914

Aerial
South
Burdick
1911

Bronson Park 1910

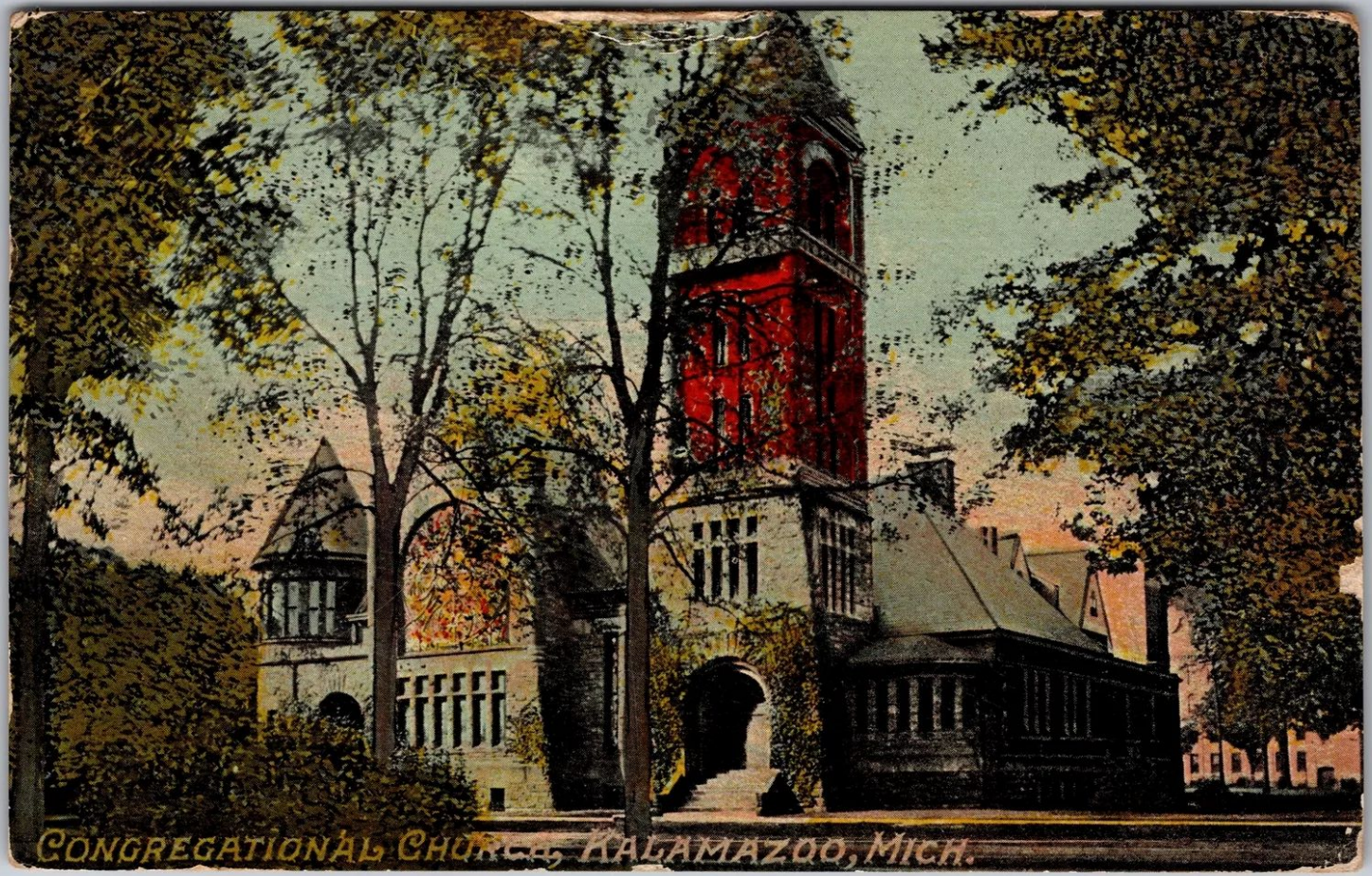
Bronson Park Fountain 1930

Burdick
1908

Burdick
1910

Central Fire Station 1905

Elks Temple 1910

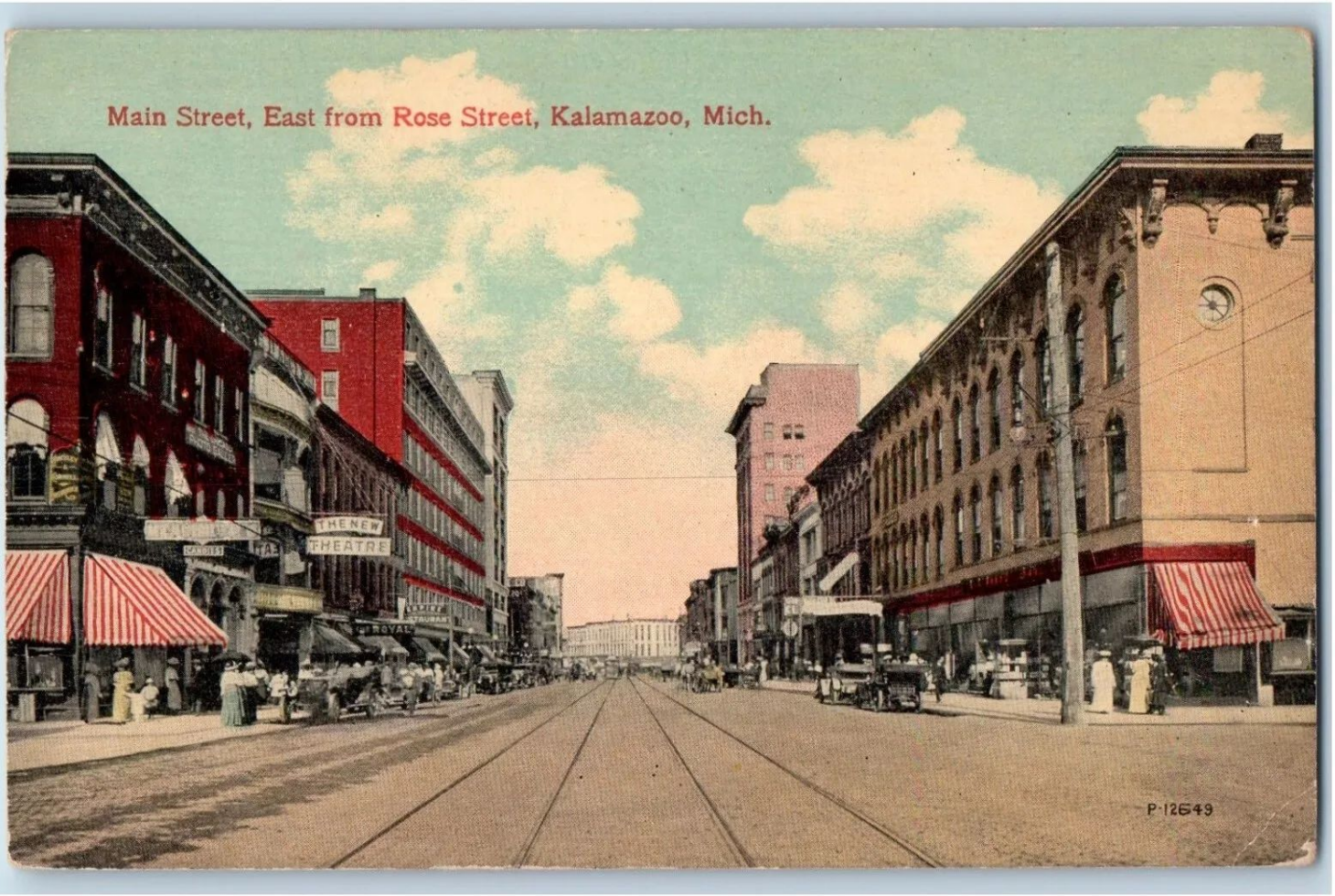


FCC 1910

FCC 1920

Library and ME Church 1910

Main Street 1923

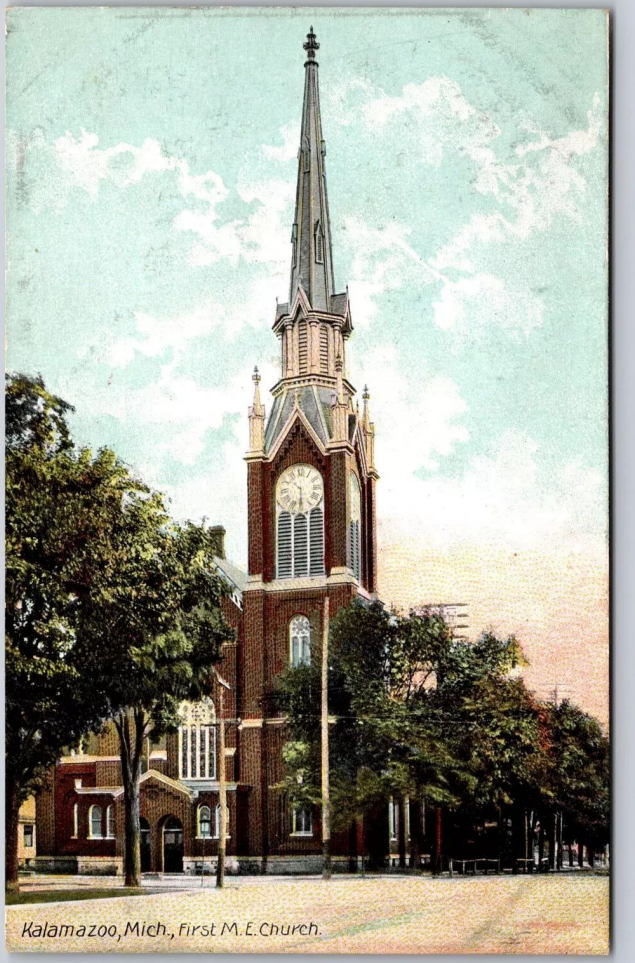


Main Street East 1910

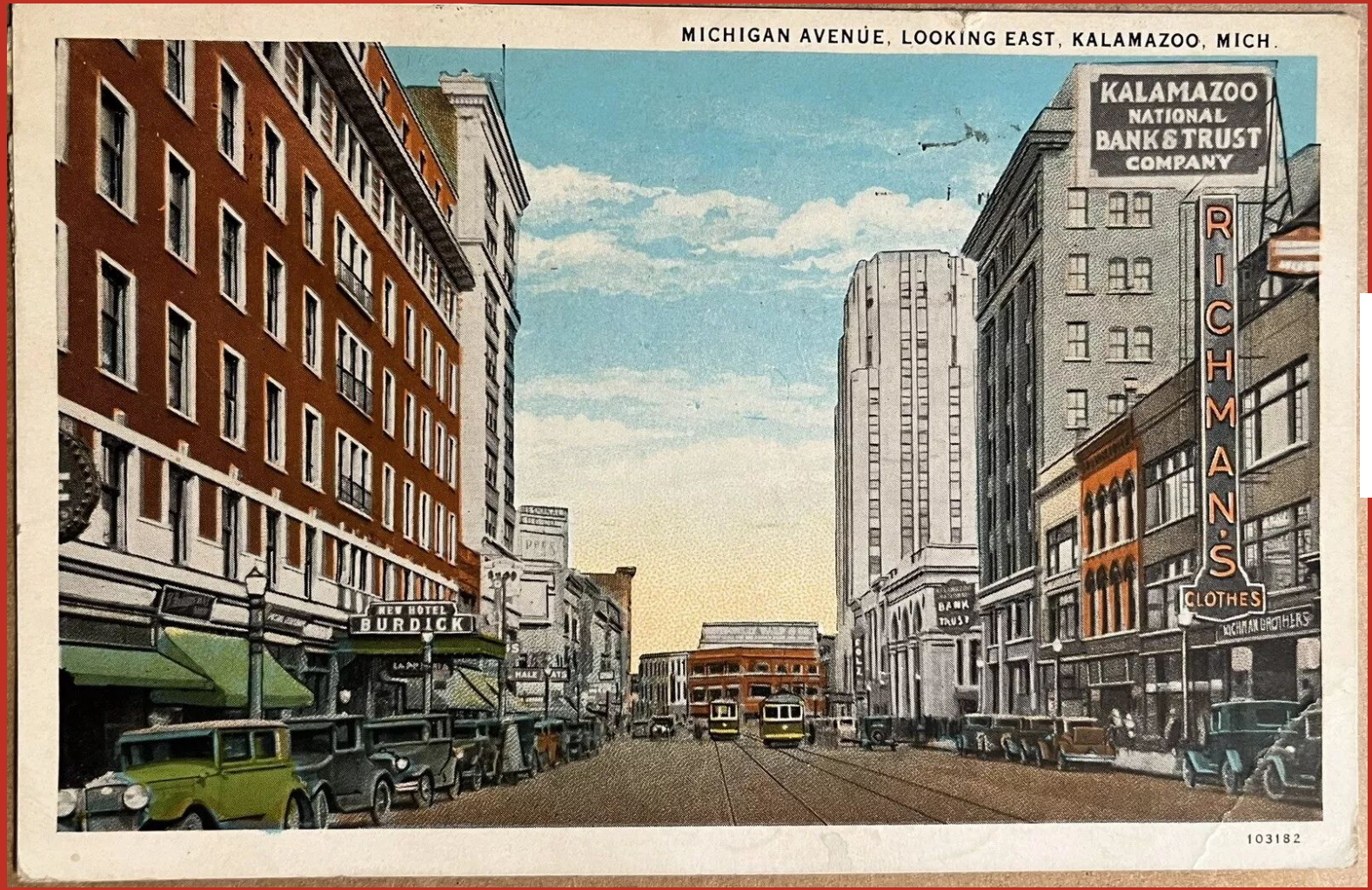
Main Street East 1924

Main Street West 1921

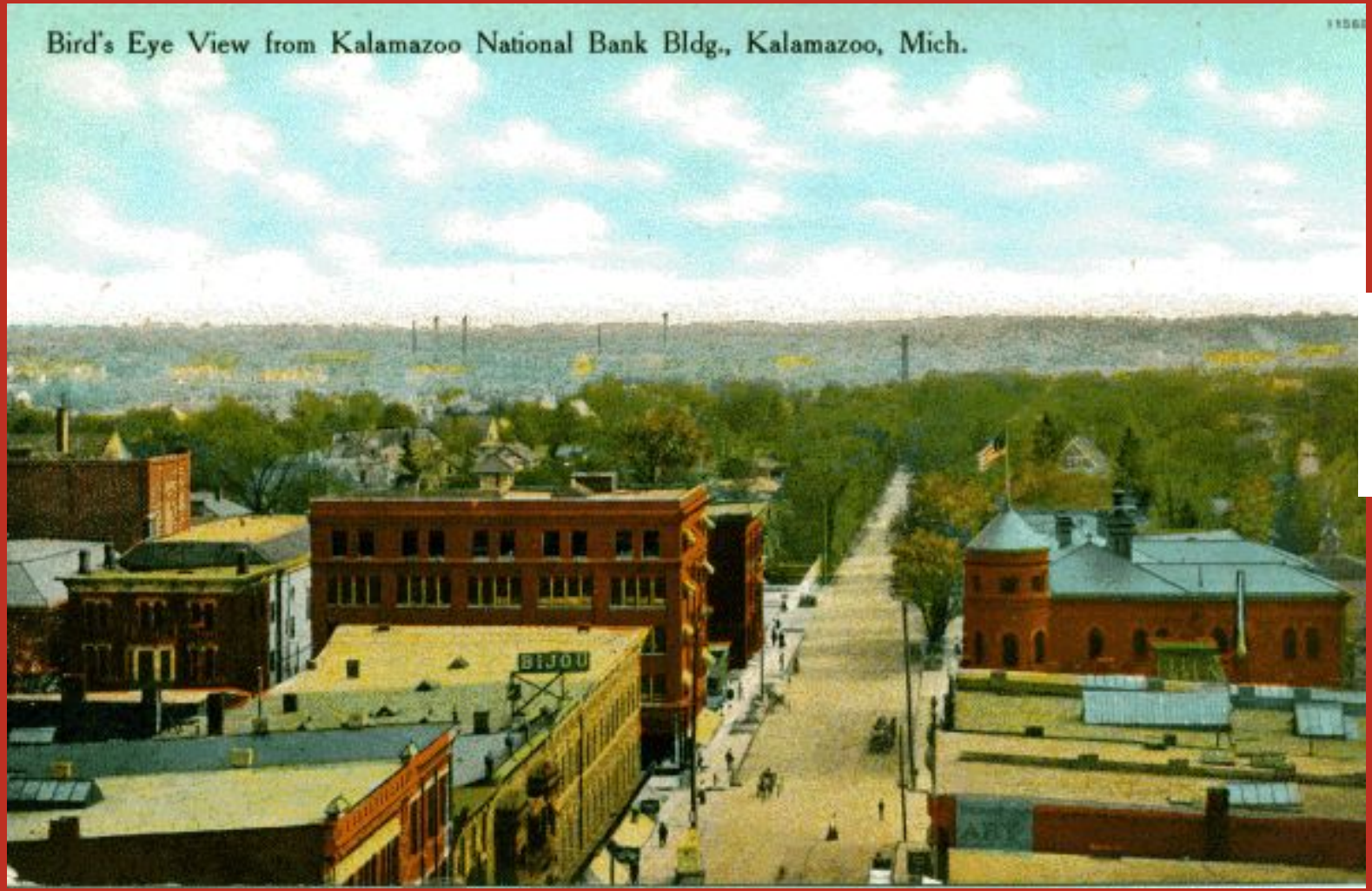
marlborough building 1920s



Methodist
1920

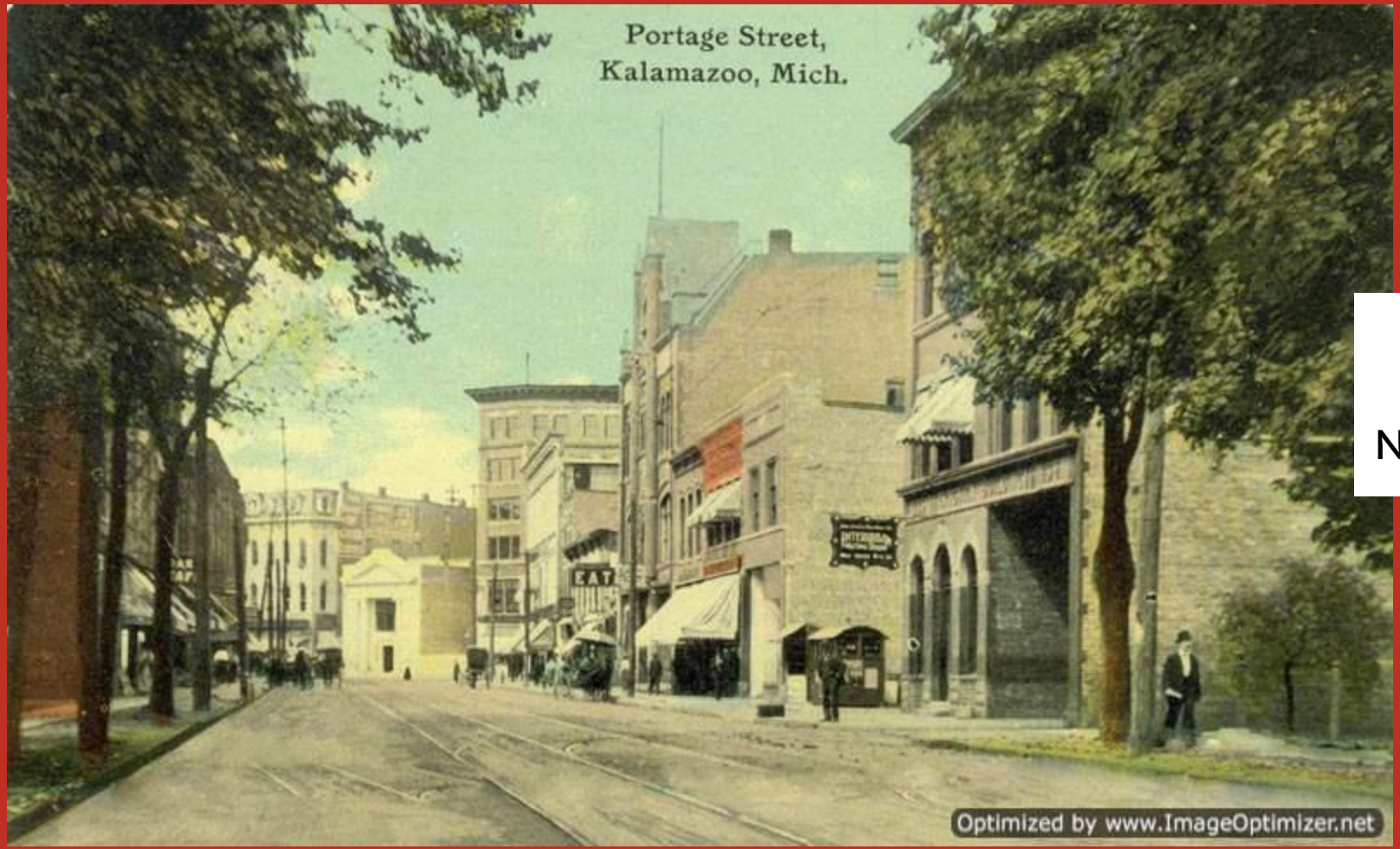


Michigan Avenue 1930

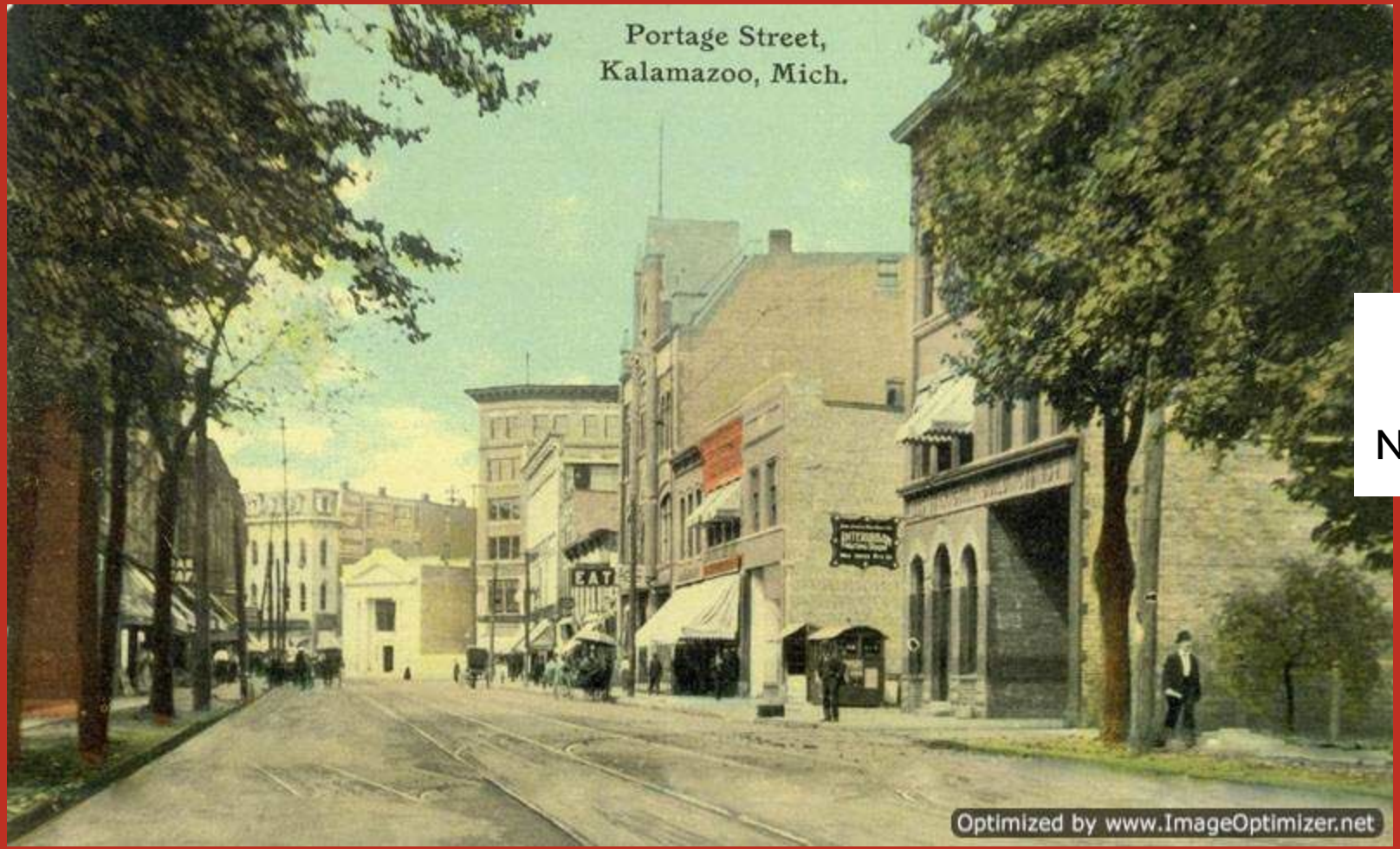


National Bank Building 1910

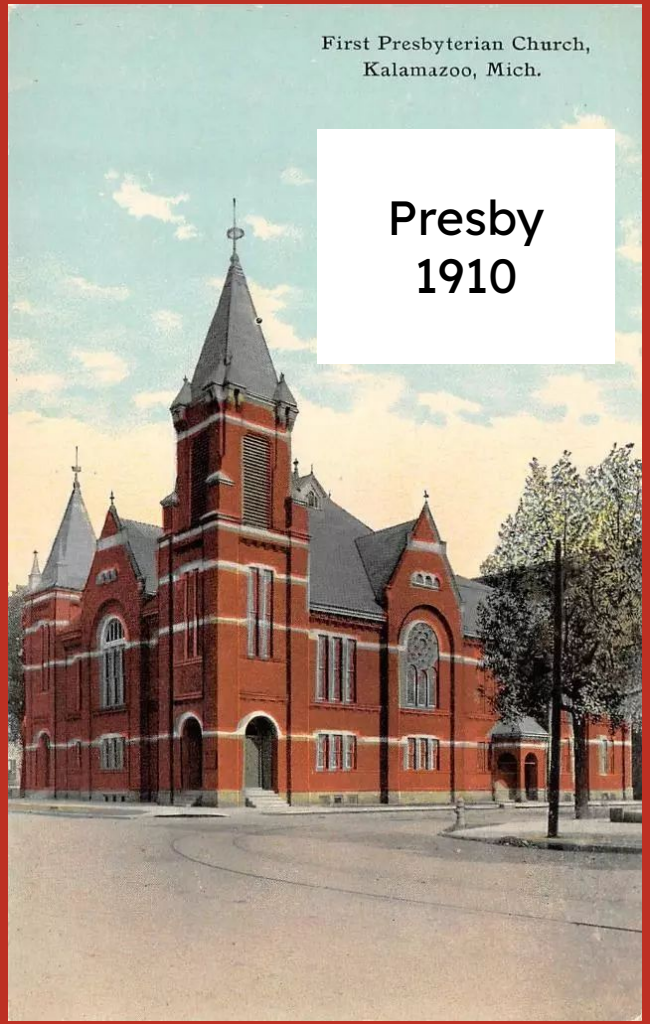
New Burdick Hotel 1912



Portage Street North 1910



Portage Street North 1910



Presby
1910

St
Augustines
Church
1911

Home Office and Laboratories

THE UPJOHN COMPANY

Kalamazoo, Mich.

40 Seventh Avenue, South, *New York City*
25 E. Pershing Road, *Kansas City*
199 First Street, *San Francisco*
299 South Front Street, *Memphis, Tennessee*

I will call on or about 9/25/32

Cordially yours, F. M. Pearce

Upjohn
1920

Seven Churches 1907

West South Street 1909